

THMastery

Game Design Document

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Overview..... 5
Premise..... 5
Core Design Pillars..... 5
Dialogue and Relationships..... 5
Checks and Attributes..... 5
World Exploration..... 6
Character Development..... 6
Genre Classification..... 6
Game Loops..... 7
Minor Loop..... 7
Medium Loop..... 7
Major Loop..... 7
Progression and its Systems..... 8
Experience and Attributes..... 8
Body Attributes..... 8
Character Attributes..... 8
Mind Attributes..... 8
Independent Attribute..... 9
Checks..... 9
Types of Checks..... 10
Influences on Checks..... 10
Example Scenarios..... 11
Role of Checks in Gameplay..... 11
Attribute Check Reference Table..... 11
Athletics (Physical Movement & Strength)..... 12
Dexterity (Fine Motor Skills)..... 12
Perception (Awareness & Observation)..... 12
Persuasion (Logical Argument)..... 12
Bluff (Deception)..... 13
Intimidation (Pressure & Force)..... 13
Knowledge (Academic Understanding)..... 13
Will (Mental Resistance)..... 14
Creativity (Innovation & Expression)..... 14
Luck (Fortune & Chance)..... 14
Nerve System..... 15
Course and Skill System..... 15
Course Progression..... 16
Introduction Phase..... 16
Deepening Phase..... 16
Finishing Phase..... 17
Dialog and Personality..... 18
Dialogue Framework..... 18
Current State of CRPG Dialogue Systems..... 18

THMastery's Dialogue Validation....18
Personality Trait Table....19
Personality Representatives....23
Affinity System....23
Tutorial and Learning Curve....24
Item System....25
Equipment....25
Face Clothing....26
Hats....27
Outfits....28
Trinkets....31
Hand-Held Items....32
Food....33
Category A....33
Category B....35
Category C....36
Temporary Items....37
Miscellaneous Items....38
Economy....40
Vendors....40
Collectors....40
Objectives....41
Tasks....41
Task Structure....42
Task Challenges....43
The Big Check....43
The Road Block....43
The Mystery....44
The Encounter....44
The Action Piece....44
The Quiz....44
The Production....45
The Preparation....45
The Puzzle....45
Activities....46
Example Task Chains....46
Basics of Web-Based Programming....46
Advanced Event Photography Task Chain....49
Game World....51
Core Buildings....52
Building A10....52
Building A20....52
Administrative Buildings....52
Sports Center (A13)....53
Bus Transportation System....53

Connected Locations....53
Inner Mind Spaces....54
Hub Area....54
Course Visualization Areas....54
Time System....55
Day Phases....55
Sleep Mechanics....55
Narrative & Story....56
Story Outline....56
Overview....56
Project Paradigm....56
Story Progression....56
Act 1: The New Student....56
Act 2: The Project....56
Act 3: The Crisis....57
Climax and Choice....57
The Factions....58
The Stabilizers - Department of Computer Science....58
The Synthesists - Department of Digital Media....58
The Accelerationists - Department of Mathematics....59
Faction Dynamics....59
Course and Story Integration....59
World Impact....60
User Interface....61
Information Channels....61
Wireframes....62
Game Menu....62
Inventory....62
Attributes....63
Tasks....63
Skill Tree....64
Character Sheet....65
Input and Controls....66
Mouse Controls....66
Keyboard Shortcuts....66
Action-Context Menu....67
Audio-Visual and Software Design....68
Art style....68
Core Visual Style....68
Interior Design....69
Typography....69
Assets....69
Audio....71
Sound....71
Music....72

Software Components....73
Analysis....74
Target Group Analysis....74
Personas....77
The Focused Student....77
The Story Seeker....77
The Systems Master....78
User Story Mapping....78
Competition analysis....80
Non/Low-Combat CRPG Comparison Matrix....81
Decision-Centric CRPG Comparison Matrix....82
Tactical CRPG Comparison Matrix....83
Conclusion....84
Pestel....85
Political....85
Economical....85
Social....85
Technological....85
Environmental....85
Legal....86
References....86
Demo....87
Introduction Area....87
A10 - Entrance Area....88
The Pastaria (Left Wing)....89
Main Entrance Area (Center)....89
The Mensa (Right Wing)....91
Campus....91
The A10 Area....91
The Trash Master's Domain....91
The Worksite....92
The Red House....92
Implemented User Interface....93
Menu structure....93
Attribute Menu....93
Task Menu....94
Skill Menu....95
Inventory Menu....95
Game Menu....96
Title Screen....97
Options Menu....97
Credits....98
HUD elements....99

Overview

Premise

THMastery is a non-combat, narrative-driven computer role-playing game set in a modern university environment, specifically the THM campus. Players step into the role of a new student, beginning with minimal competencies and facing the challenges of academic life. As they progress, they develop both academic skills and personal attributes through course participation, social interactions, and exploration.

What sets THMastery apart is its unique "inner mind" visualization system, where the player's imagination transforms educational concepts into interactive scenarios. This system reflects the character's personality, beliefs, and experiences, turning potentially dry academic content into engaging adventures. The game maintains a light-hearted tone, using humor and fantastical elements to balance the serious aspects of university life.

Core Design Pillars



Dialogue and Relationships

The game's story unfolds primarily through conversations with a diverse cast of characters. Players interact with fellow students, eccentric professors, and even manifestations of their character's imagination. These relationships evolve based on player choices and actions, creating a dynamic social environment that reflects the character's growing personality.

Checks and Attributes

Instead of traditional combat, challenges take the form of checks embedded in dialogue and interactions. The difficulty of these checks depends not only on the character's abilities but

also on their past actions and acquired knowledge, creating a complex web of cause and effect that encourages thoughtful play.

World Exploration

The university campus is presented as a handcrafted, interactive environment filled with secrets and hidden opportunities. Beyond the physical campus, the character's inner mind offers an ever-changing fantastic space that reflects their academic journey and personal growth. This dual-world approach provides both grounded and imaginative exploration opportunities.

Character Development

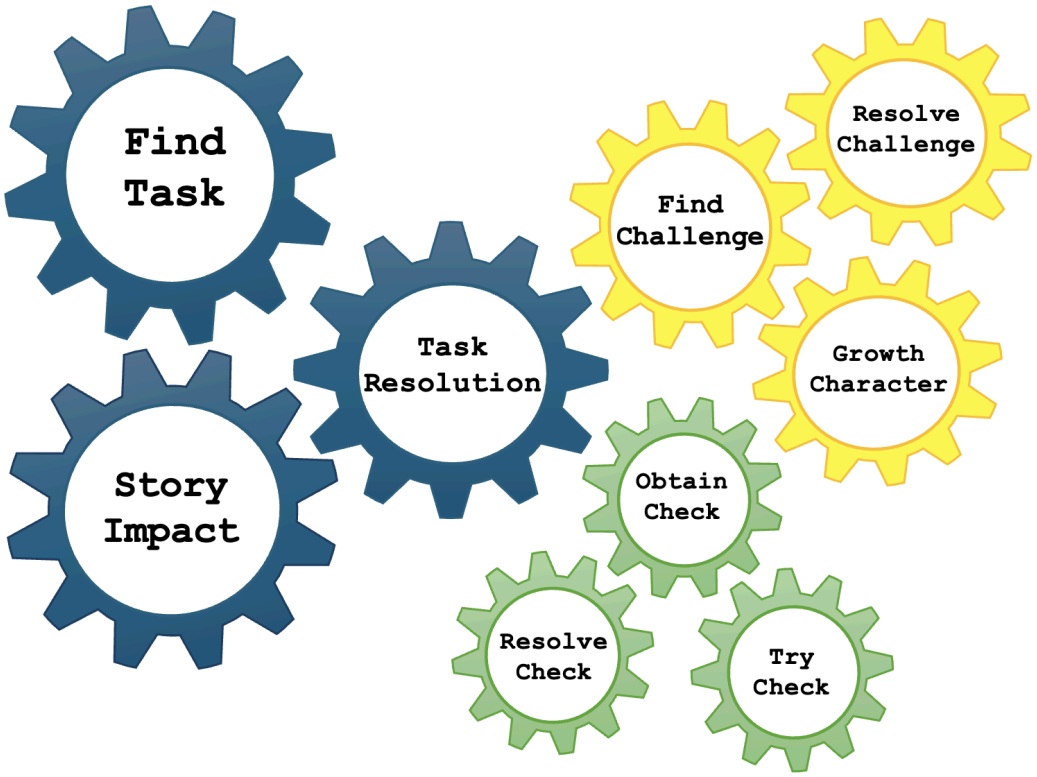
Players begin as a blank slate, with their character's strengths and personality shaped by their choices throughout the game. Through course selection, relationship building, and problem-solving approaches, each player creates a unique student identity. This development affects both gameplay options and story outcomes, ensuring that each playthrough can feel distinctly personal.

Genre Classification

The game is a narrative no-combat CRPG.

- **Computer Role-Playing Game (CRPG)**: Draws from tabletop RPG traditions, utilizing dice rolls, attribute checks, and character development to create an experience focused on player choice and expression through mechanical systems.
- **Narrative Focus**: Places story and character relationships at the forefront, with progress driven by dialogue and interactions that shape both the player's journey and the world around them.
- **No-Combat Design**: Replaces traditional RPG combat with academic and social challenges, where conflicts are resolved through creative problem-solving, skill application, and meaningful character interaction.

Game Loops



THMastery's gameplay is structured around three interconnected loops of increasing scope.

Minor Loop

The foundational gameplay loop centers on individual skill checks, which form the basic unit of challenge in THMastery. Players obtain checks through exploration and dialogue, attempt them using their character's attributes and modifiers, and experience immediate outcomes that lead to new opportunities. This continuous cycle of discovery, attempt, and resolution drives the moment-to-moment gameplay experience.

Medium Loop

Building upon individual checks, the medium loop encompasses broader objectives that require multiple skill checks to resolve. Success in these challenges drives character progression through experience gain and items. As characters advance, they can tackle more higher level checks, creating a satisfying progression cycle where individual successes contribute to long-term development.

Major Loop

The outer loop provides narrative context through tasks that combine multiple challenges into meaningful story arcs. Task discovery leads to a series of connected challenges, culminating in resolutions that impact both the game's story and world state. These larger narrative arcs give purpose to the inner loops, ensuring that individual checks and challenges contribute to a coherent storyline.

Progression and its Systems

Experience and Attributes

The foundation of character progression in THMastery is built on an experience point system that governs attribute development. Experience points (XP) are awarded exclusively through meaningful accomplishments rather than repeatable actions. Upon accumulating 100 experience points, the player receives one attribute point to distribute.

Experience points are awarded through:

- Completing tasks (~100 XP based on complexity)
- Succeeding in significant skill checks (5-15 XP based on difficulty)
- Finishing courses (~150 XP based on on complexity and course level)
- Unlocking new areas (10-25 XP based on area significance)

The attributes are divided into three primary categories, each containing three attributes, plus one independent attribute. They represent the characters strengths and weaknesses and are tested in checks:

Body	Character	Mind
Athletics	Persuasion	Knowledge
Dexterity	Bluff	Will
Perception	Intimidation	Creativity
Luck		

Body Attributes

- Athletics: Determines physical capabilities like running, climbing, and lifting
- Dexterity: Controls fine motor skills, precision tasks, and manual dexterity
- Perception: Affects awareness of surroundings and ability to notice details

Character Attributes

- Persuasion: Influences ability to convince others through logical argument
- Bluff: Controls capacity to deceive or misdirect others
- Intimidation: Determines effectiveness at pressuring or imposing will on others

Mind Attributes

- Knowledge: Affects academic understanding and technical comprehension
- Will: Controls stress resistance and determination
- Creativity: Influences ability to find novel solutions and artistic expression

Independent Attribute

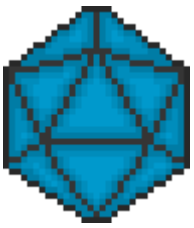
- Luck: Determines probability of favorable random events and passive discoveries. It cannot be leveled through attribute points

Attribute points are used to level an attributes value by one. Through regular leveling using these attribute points each attribute can be leveled to a maximum of 20. This only presents a soft maximum as it can be surpassed with other attribute boosting effects. Each attribute group (Body, Character, Mind) provides synergy bonuses based on the total points invested in that group. For every 10 points accumulated across all attributes within a group, every attribute in that group receives a +1 bonus.

For example:

- Body Group with Athletics 4, Dexterity 3, Perception 3 (Total: 10) = +1 to all Body attributes
- Character Group with Persuasion 7, Bluff 6, Intimidation 7 (Total: 20) = +2 to all Character attributes
- Mind Group with Knowledge 8, Will 8, Creativity 4 (Total: 20) = +2 to all Mind attributes

This system aims to create a balance attribute distribution. While it rewards focused investment in attribute groups through synergy bonuses, the threshold of 10 points means players can still effectively spread their points across different attributes without severe penalties. A character can maintain competence in multiple areas while still benefiting from moderate specialization.



Checks

In *THMastery*, checks are a fundamental gameplay mechanic used to test a character's attributes when facing challenges. Each check targets a single specific attribute, representing the character's competence in that area. However, the quality of any given action can still vary, regardless of skill. This variability is represented by a die roll, which, when combined with the attribute's value, determines the final outcome. To succeed, the total must meet or exceed the difficulty threshold of the check.

Functionally a check is an event where the game compares the character's relevant attribute value and a dice roll against the check's difficulty. The formula for resolving a check is:

$$Success = (Attribute\,Value + Dice\,Roll) \geq (Base\,Difficulty + \sum Influences)$$

The difficulty represents the baseline challenge, which can be modified by contextual influences that stem from prior decisions or situational elements. Influences can raise or lower the difficulty, making strategic planning and awareness critical.

Types of Checks

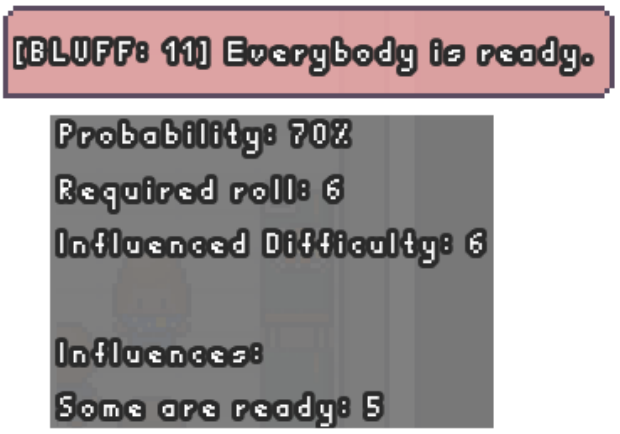
There are two types of checks in the game: active and passive. Active checks require player interaction through dialogue or actions, and their success depends on both attributes and dice rolls. Passive checks happen automatically in the background without player input, simply checking if the character's attribute meets the required threshold.

Feature	Active Checks	Passive Checks
Player Input	Requires direct engagement through dialogue options or actions.	Occurs automatically without player input.
Use Case	Common during pivotal moments like persuading NPCs or solving complex problems.	Used to reveal hidden details, unlock additional dialogue options, or provide subtle narrative context.
Outcome Variability	Depends on attribute value, dice roll, and influenced difficulty.	Success is based solely on whether the attribute value meets or exceeds the difficulty; influences do not apply.
Failure Consequences	Failing can lead to alternative paths or additional challenges.	No negative consequences; failure means certain content remains inaccessible.
Repeatability	Can be repeatable or single-chance challenges.	Typically single occurrence, offering no retries but no risks either.

Influences on Checks

Active checks are affected by influences, which adjust their difficulty. These influences arise from:

- **Decisions & Actions**: Choices such as aligning with an institute or breaking academic rules can increase the difficulty of checks tied to related NPCs or tasks.
- **Dialogue Choices**: Prior conversations may shape how NPCs react, making subsequent persuasion or bluff checks easier or harder.
- **Contextual Modifiers**: Factors like wearing specific clothing, possessing certain skills, or having unlocked relevant information may alter difficulty.



For instance, a check with a base difficulty of 10 might have an additional +3 difficulty due to prior dialogue choices, raising the influenced difficulty to 13.

Example Scenarios

1. Active Check with Negative Influence:

    - Task: Convince an NPC to provide critical information.
    - Difficulty: Base 10.
    - Influence: A prior insult to the NPC adds +3 to the difficulty.
    - Player's Attribute: Persuasion 7.
    - Result: The influenced difficulty is 13. The player must roll at least a 6 on the dice to succeed (Persuasion 7 + Dice Roll = 13).

2. Passive Check Example:

    - Task: Identify misleading information in a professor's lecture.
    - Difficulty: Base 12.
    - Player's Attribute: Perception 8.
    - Result: Success occurs if the player's Perception (8) meets or exceeds the difficulty (12). In this case, the player fails to detect the misleading comment.

Role of Checks in Gameplay

Checks deepen both the narrative and gameplay experience by tying challenges to the player's choices and strategies. Success or failure in checks impacts:

- **Narrative Outcomes**: Unlocking new story paths, altering relationships with NPCs, or providing unique insights.
- **Gameplay Options**: Revealing hidden tasks, opening alternate solutions, or offering specialized rewards.

This system ensures that every check contributes meaningfully to the player's journey, making *THMastery* an engaging and reflective gaming experience.

Attribute Check Reference Table

This reference table provides examples of attribute checks across different difficulty levels for all attributes in THMastery. Each difficulty range (from 3-25) represents increasingly challenging tasks that can be attempted using the corresponding attribute. The examples given for each difficulty are representative but not exhaustive - they serve as guidelines for creating similar checks within that difficulty range.

When using this table, note that the final difficulty of a check can be modified by various influences such as equipment, skills, or previous actions. The number in parentheses after each example represents its base difficulty before any modifiers are applied.

Athletics (Physical Movement & Strength)

Difficulty	Example Check
3-5	Jump puddle (3), Carry groceries (4), Catch bus (5)
8-10	Climb window (8), Campus sprint (9), Move desk (10)
12-15	Parkour benches (12), Scale building (14), Win tournament (15)
17-20	Rooftop run (17), Climb tower (18), Regional championship in sport (20)
22-25	Acrobatics (22), Speed climbing (24), Extreme course (25)

Dexterity (Fine Motor Skills)

Difficulty	Example Check
3-5	Touch type (3), Draw line (4), Basic origami (5)
8-10	Pick lock (8), Technical drawing (9), Juggle (10)
12-15	Fix electronics (12), Complex origami (14), Advanced locks (15)
17-20	Microsurgery (17), Build machines (19), Multi-juggle (20)
22-25	Build robot (22), Pro art (24), Master repairs (25)

Perception (Awareness & Observation)

Difficulty	Example Check
3-5	Notice wave (3), Find pen (4), Spot changes (5)
8-10	Detect lies (8), Notice details (9), Find door (10)
12-15	Spot cheating (12), Find cameras (14), Spot forgery (15)
17-20	System changes (17), Read body language (19), Find secrets (20)
22-25	See anomalies (22), Predict actions (24), Solve mysteries (25)

Persuasion (Logical Argument)

Difficulty	Example Check
3-5	Ask directions (3), Borrow notes (4), Get extension (5)
8-10	Review grade (8), Negotiate prices (9), Mediate conflict (10)

Difficulty	Example Check
12-15	Win debate (12), Change policy (14), Complex deals (15)
17-20	Unite factions (17), Change beliefs (19), Political debate (20)
22-25	Faculty reform (22), University policy (24), Unite paradigms (25)

Bluff (Deception)

Difficulty	Example Check
3-5	Late excuse (3), Fake understanding (4), Hide nerves (5)
8-10	Fake note (8), Impersonate student (9), Access area (10)
12-15	False identity (12), Fool security (14), Win poker (15)
17-20	Con scheme (17), Multiple identities (19), Infiltrate (20)
22-25	Fool systems (22), Perfect forgery (24), Deceive reality (25)

Intimidation (Pressure & Force)

Difficulty	Example Check
3-5	Stop cutting (3), Defend seat (4), Quiet library (5)
8-10	Priority service (8), Stop fights (9), Command groups (10)
12-15	Stop trouble (12), Force confession (14), Control chaos (15)
17-20	Fear presence (17), Control crowds (19), Stop danger (20)
22-25	Ultimate fear (22), Command all (24), Reality force (25)

Knowledge (Academic Understanding)

Difficulty	Example Check
3-5	Remember schedule (3), Basic concepts (4), Simple work (5)
8-10	Complex theory (8), Research paper (9), Tech problems (10)
12-15	Quantum physics (12), New theories (14), Math proofs (15)
17-20	Discoveries (17), Reality theory (19), New science (20)
22-25	Reality fabric (22), Consciousness (24), Existence (25)

Will (Mental Resistance)

Difficulty	Example Check
3-5	Stay awake (3), Focus basic (4), Minor stress (5)
8-10	All-nighter (8), Resist pressure (9), Exam stress (10)
12-15	Extreme focus (12), Mental defense (14), Major setback (15)
17-20	Reality resist (17), Chaos sanity (19), Mind defense (20)
22-25	Shape reality (22), Total breakdown (24), Control chaos (25)

Creativity (Innovation & Expression)

Difficulty	Example Check
3-5	Basic sketch (3), Short writing (4), Simple solution (5)
8-10	Unique art (8), Creative solve (9), New project (10)
12-15	Art install (12), New theory (14), Revolutionary idea (15)
17-20	Reality art (17), New concepts (19), Impossible solve (20)
22-25	Shape reality (22), New existence (24), Beyond limits (25)

Luck (Fortune & Chance)

Difficulty	Example Check
3-5	Find money (3), Green lights (4), Good seat (5)
8-10	Win contest (8), Find value (9), Avoid accident (10)
12-15	Win prize (12), Find needs (14), Major avoid (15)
17-20	Win chance (17), Make coincidence (19), Bend odds (20)
22-25	Control random (22), Impossible luck (24), Shape chance (25)

Nerve System



Beyond attributes and skills, characters in THMastery have a vital statistic called nerve that represents their mental and emotional resilience. Much like health systems in traditional games, nerve measures how close a character is to breaking down under stress. The system is intrinsically linked to the Will attribute, which determines the maximum nerve value a character can have.

When characters experience stressful situations, they lose nerve points. This stress doesn't just deplete their nerve - it also temporarily reduces their Will attribute, creating a downward spiral effect where stress makes them more vulnerable to further stress. If a character's nerve is completely depleted, they experience a mental breakdown, resulting in a game over.

Characters can recover their nerve through various means, collectively referred to as "stress relief" in-game. The most straightforward method is sleep, which fully restores nerve points. Many items in the game also provide stress relief - from comfort food to recreational activities. Additionally, successfully resolving stressful situations or completing certain activities can help restore nerve points.

Course and Skill System

Courses serve as a core progression mechanic in THMastery. Each course costs one potential point to unlock and grants specific skills upon completion. Players receive a limited number of potential points throughout the game, requiring strategic choices about which courses to take.

The course system functions through attribute requirements, course prerequisites, and the skills they provide. For example, a second-semester programming course might require completion of a first-semester programming fundamentals course and a minimum knowledge attribute score. This creates natural progression paths while allowing players flexibility in how they develop their character.

When a player completes a course, they gain permanent access to its associated skill. These skills provide concrete mechanical benefits like new dialogue options, additional solutions to challenges, and influences to relevant skill checks. Since players cannot take every course in a single playthrough, their course choices directly shape their character's capabilities and available problem-solving approaches.





Course Progression

The course system in THMastery mirrors the structure of a Digital Media Systems degree program, dividing the academic journey into three distinct phases: Introduction, Deepening, and Finishing. Each phase serves a specific purpose in both gameplay and character development.

Introduction Phase

The game begins with three mandatory basic courses, each representing one of the main study paths: IT, Media, and Management. These introductory courses serve to familiarize players with the course mechanics while allowing them to experience different aspects of the curriculum before committing to a specialization.

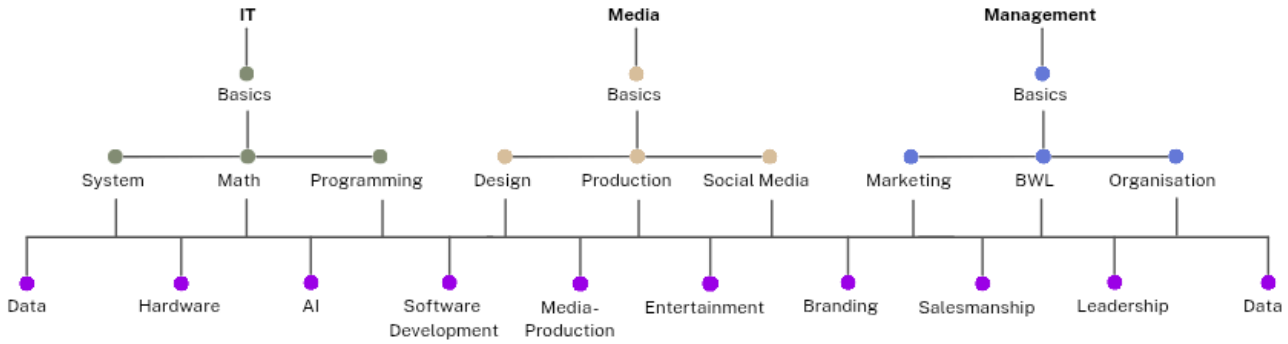
Understanding that not all character builds will be suited for every course type, each introductory course offers a "cheat path." This alternative progression route allows players to bypass skill checks they might not be equipped to handle. While choosing the cheat path doesn't consume a potential point, it also doesn't reward the associated skill upon completion.

Deepening Phase

After completing the introduction, players enter the deepening phase where the curriculum branches into specialized paths. As shown in the learning tree, each main path (IT, Media, and Management) splits into three specialized tracks:

- IT branches into Systems, Math, and Programming
- Media divides into Design, Production, and Social Media
- Management separates into Marketing, BWL, and Organisation

These specialized courses culminate in advanced subjects like Data Analysis, AI, Software Development, Entertainment, Branding, Salesmanship, Leadership, and Data Management. While players have significant freedom in choosing their courses, they must respect prerequisites - both in terms of completed courses and attribute requirements.



The acquisition of potential points, needed to unlock courses, is primarily tied to main story progression. This creates a natural rhythm where players alternate between advancing the story and taking courses. The system is deliberately designed this way for two reasons:

1. Skills gained from courses help players handle increasingly difficult story challenges
2. Story progression gates access to more advanced courses

This integration prevents players from front-loading all courses before tackling the story, which would otherwise allow them to face story challenges with a full complement of skills.

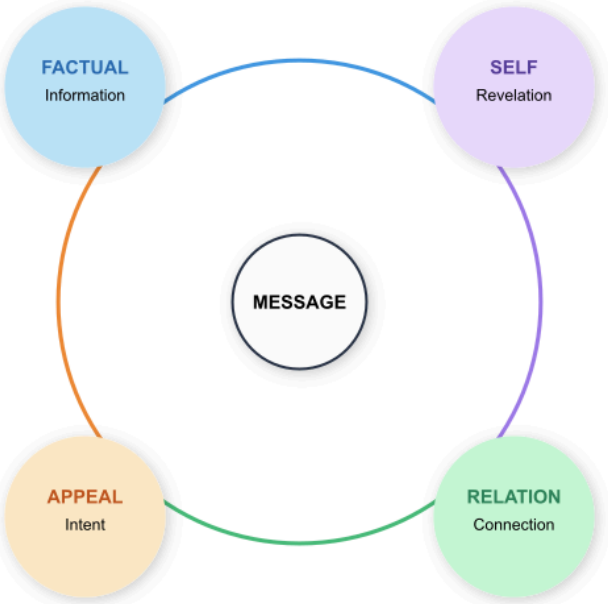
Finishing Phase

The academic journey culminates in a significant task chain centered around the creation of a bachelor thesis. This final project manifests as a powerful equipment item for the hand slot, with its effects varying based on the skills acquired throughout the game. The thesis project serves as both a capstone to the academic experience and a reward that reflects the player's chosen specialization path.

Dialog and Personality

Dialogue Framework

The game features a traditional CRPG dialogue system where conversations branch based on player choices. To ensure meaningful choices and avoid purely decorative options, each dialogue choice is validated through game systems, drawing inspiration from Schulz von Thun's four-sided communication model.



The four-sided model posits that every communication contains four messages: a factual layer (what is being said), an appeal layer (what is being requested), a relation layer (what it says about the relationship between speakers), and a self-revelation layer (what it reveals about the speaker). This model provides a framework for understanding how different types of dialogue choices can be validated through distinct game systems.

Current State of CRPG Dialogue Systems

Most RPG dialogue systems primarily focus on validating two aspects of communication. Factual choices drive the narrative or gather information, while appeal choices make direct requests of NPCs. CRPGs usually expand this by implementing reputation systems to validate relationship-level communication. However, the self-revelation layer often remains unvalidated, with character-defining choices having little mechanical impact.

THMastery's Dialogue Validation

In THMastery, all four communication layers are mechanically validated:

Factual choices advance tasks, unlock new information, or reveal task objectives. Rather than just providing flavor text, information-gathering choices always connect to the game's progression systems.

Appeal choices, such as requests or demands, are validated through the skill check system. The success of these choices depends on both the character's attributes and their existing relationship with the NPC.

The relationship layer is implemented through individual NPC affinity tracking. These relationships affect dialogue check difficulties and unlock unique conversation options. Past interactions create lasting consequences for future conversations.

The self-revelation layer connects to the personality system. Character-defining dialogue choices contribute to personality traits, which unlock corresponding rooms in the inner mind where the player can pick up the personality trait if they want it. This ensures that how players express their character through dialogue has concrete gameplay effects through mechanical benefits and drawbacks.

By implementing systems to validate all four layers of communication, every dialogue choice in THMastery serves a mechanical purpose beyond narrative flavor.

Personality Trait Table

Name	Positive Effects	Negative Effects	Unlock Condition
Greedy	+ Additional dialogue options for increased rewards + 2 Bluff	- 1 Persuasion - Lose 10 nerve when declining rewards	Select reward-increasing dialogue options 10 times
Know-It-All	+ Gain 10 XP for each successful Knowledge check + 2 Knowledge	- Failed Knowledge checks cost 1 nerve - 2 Persuasion	Pass 15 Knowledge checks
Kind-Hearted	+ Gain 15 XP when completing tasks without reward + 3 Persuasion	- 2 Bluff - Lose 10 nerve when stealing items	Complete 5 tasks without taking rewards
Pacifist	+ 3 Persuasion + Gain 10 XP from resolving conflicts peacefully	- 2 Intimidation - Aggressive dialogue options locked	Choose peaceful resolutions 10 times
Artist	+ 3 Creativity + Gain 10 XP from successful Creativity checks	- 2 Knowledge - Failed Creativity checks cost 5 nerve	Pass 10 Creativity checks
Collector	+ 500 XP + 1 Will	- Cannot progress main story until all collectibles in current zone found	Find 50% of any zone's collectibles
Gourmet	+ Can have two food buffs active + 1 Perception	- Food items cost twice as much - 1 Will	Try 15 different food items

Name	Positive Effects	Negative Effects	Unlock Condition
Pathological Liar	+ Gain 10 XP from successful Bluff checks + 2 Bluff	- Failed Bluff checks cost 2 nerve - 2 Persuasion	Use Bluff dialogue options 15 times
Chatterbox	+ 2 Persuasion All dialogue options visible without checks	- 2 Intimidation - Each dialogue costs 2 nerve	Exhaust all dialogue options with 5 NPCs
Autodidact	+ Double XP from reading documents + 2 Knowledge	- 50% reduced XP from course completion - 1 Persuasion	Read 15 unique documents
Vegetarian	+ Double nerve restoration from plant-based foods + 1 Will	- Cannot consume meat items - 1 Athletics	Avoid meat items for an entire chapter
Bad with Money	+ 25% better prices when selling + 2 Persuasion	- Cannot haggle prices down - Money-related checks always fail	Spend over 500€ in shops
Kleptomaniac	+ Gain 10 XP when stealing + 2 Dexterity	- Lose 5 nerve when passing stealable items - 1 Persuasion	Successfully steal 10 items
Mysterious	+ 2 Intimidation + Access to cryptic dialogue options	- 2 Persuasion - Standard greetings cost 2 nerve	Choose cryptic dialogue options 10 times
Anti-Materialist	+ 20 XP when giving away items + 2 Will	- Cannot carry more than 5 non-essential items - 1 Bluff	Give away 20 items
Hot Headed	+ 2 Intimidation during arguments + Aggressive options always available	- 2 Persuasion - Lose 5 nerve when picking calm options	Choose aggressive dialogue options 10 times
Hypochondriac	+ Double effect from healing items + 2 Perception	- Lose 2 nerve every hour - 1 Will	Use 20 healing items

Name	Positive Effects	Negative Effects	Unlock Condition
Alcoholic	+ Triple nerve restoration from alcoholic drinks + 1 Bluff	- Cannot restore nerve without consuming alcohol - 1 Knowledge	Consume 15 alcoholic beverages
Introvert	+ 2 Knowledge when no ongoing tasks + Double XP from solo activities	- 2 Persuasion - halves faction affinity gaines	Complete 10 tasks without dialogue
Extrovert	+ 2 Persuasion with NPCs you haven't talked to + Extra dialogue options	- 2 Persuasion with NPCs you have affinity with	Talk to 20 different NPCs
Master-Metabolist	+ Food effects last twice as long + 1 Athletics	- Nerve decay occurs twice as fast - 1 Will	Use 20 different food items
Follower of Fate	+ All Luck checks have advantage + 3 Luck	- Cannot reload saves - 1 Knowledge	Accept 10 random outcomes
Highly Cultured	+ 2 Knowledge + Access to sophisticated dialogue	- 2 Athletics - Casual dialogue options locked	Use sophisticated dialogue 15 times
Pauper	+ 20% better prices everywhere + 2 Will	- Cannot carry more than 20€ - 1 Persuasion	Complete tasks while having less than 10€
Temple Body	+ Food healing doubled + 2 Athletics	- Cannot eat junk food - 1 Bluff	Consume 20 healthy food items
Dumb	+ 15 XP from failed Knowledge checks + 3 Luck	- 2 Knowledge - Cannot access certain dialogue options	Fail 10 Knowledge checks
The Adventurer	+ 1 to all body attributes + Unique dialogue options	- 1 to all mental attributes - Must accept all tasks	Accept 20 different tasks

Name	Positive Effects	Negative Effects	Unlock Condition
Free-Mover	+ 2 Athletics when no temporary effects active + Faster movement speed	- 2 Athletics when under temporary effects - 1 Will	Travel without effects for one hour
Hands-Free	+ 2 Dexterity when no temp items active + Access to special interactions	- 2 Dexterity with active items - Cannot use multiple temp items	Complete 10 tasks without items
Outdoorsman	+ Double food effects outside + 1 Athletics + 1 Perception	- Half food effects inside - 1 Knowledge	Spend 2 hours outside buildings
Civilized	+ Double healing effects inside + 1 Persuasion + 1 Knowledge	- Half healing effects outside - 1 Athletics	Spend 4 hours inside buildings
Unlucky One	+ 600 XP + Unique dialogue options	- 3 Luck - Shop prices increased by 25%	Fail 40 skill checks
Superstitious	+ +3 Luck when carrying lucky items + Access to special dialogue	- 2 Knowledge - Must have lucky item equipped	Collect 5 lucky items
Strong Body/Weak Mind	+ 3 Athletics + 2 Dexterity	- 3 Knowledge - 2 Creativity	Have body of above 3 while mind is below 1
Strong Mind/Weak Body	+ 3 Knowledge + 2 Creativity	- 3 Athletics - 2 Dexterity	Have mind of above 3 while body is below 1
Indestructible	+ Nerve restoration doubled + 1 Will	- Maximum nerve halved - 1 Perception	Survive 50 nerve damage
Master of Moments	+ 3 Perception + 2 Creativity	- 1 Knowledge	Get high quality photos done in “Advanced Event Photography”

Personality Representatives

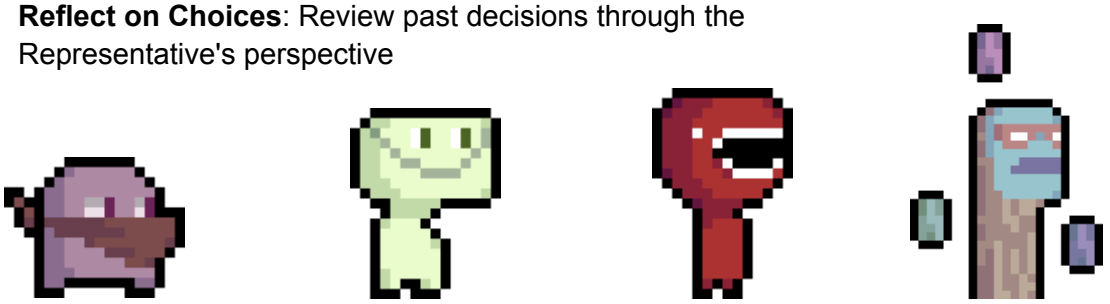
The personality trait system in THMastery is further enhanced by the concept of Representatives - manifestations of certain personality traits that appear as distinct characters within the player's inner mind. These Representatives serve multiple purposes in both the narrative and mechanical aspects of the game.

When a Representative's corresponding personality trait has been unlocked, they become active participants in the player's decision-making process. During key dialogue moments, Representatives will interject with their perspectives:

- The Greedy Representative points out opportunities for material gain that aren't immediately obvious
- The Know-It-All Representative provides additional context about a topic being discussed
- The Kind-Hearted Representative highlights how certain dialogue choices impact others emotionally

Each Representative inhabits their personality trait's unique room within the inner mind space, which becomes accessible once their corresponding trait is unlocked. Players can visit these rooms to:

1. **Engage in Direct Dialogue**: Have philosophical discussions with the Representative about their worldview
2. **Receive Guidance**: Get specific advice about current tasks or situations
3. **Reflect on Choices**: Review past decisions through the Representative's perspective



Affinity System

THMastery tracks individual affinity ratings for recurring NPCs and those involved in significant social interactions as well as the three major factions from the main task-chain. Affinity is tracked on a scale of 1-100, analogous to percentages. This affinity directly affects the difficulty of social skill checks in different ways. Persuasion checks become easier when an NPC has high affinity with the player - they're more likely to be convinced by someone they trust. The opposite is true for Intimidation checks, which work better on NPCs with low affinity since they're already wary or fearful of them. For bluff checks, the effect of affinity depends on the type of lie being told. Some lies, like pretending to be a friend trying to help, work better with high affinity because the NPC already trusts you. Other lies, like claiming to be an authority figure checking for violations, might be more effective with low affinity because the NPC already sees you as a threatening figure.

Tutorial and Learning Curve

The game begins in the player's home, a small area that serves as the initial tutorial space. The area contains one instance of each core interaction type and centers around a morning routine task. The space is deliberately compact and contains exactly one instance of each important interaction type for players to discover. Players need to complete several actions to prepare for their first university day:

- Get dressed (equipment usage)
- Eat breakfast (food items)
- Drink coffee (temporary items)
- Read university flyer (readable items)

During this sequence, players encounter basic dialogue and two skill checks - one with a low difficulty that's likely to succeed, and one with a higher difficulty that is likely to fail.

The home area includes pop-up windows that explain the controls, interaction methods, and UI elements when players first encounter them. These windows explain the basic functionality of each system. Similarly, each game menu (inventory, character sheet, etc.) triggers an explanation window the first time it is opened, explaining that menu's specific functions and controls.

Upon reaching the university's introductory class, players learn about the course system and receive their first main task. This introduces both the course system and the main task chain.

After the introductory class, players gain access to the full game world, which is divided into distinct but interconnected areas. Players can freely explore these areas and engage with all the mechanics they learned in the tutorial section.

Item System

Items are collectible objects in the world that are stored in the player's inventory. All items in the game serve a purpose, there are no trash items without use. Each item must have:

- A name that serves as a unique identifier
- A description that can be read in the inventory or when inspected
- A texture that represents it both in the world and in inventory

Optionally items can also have:

- An inspection text that can be read in inventory or when examining in-world. This overrides the description when inspecting item
- A use message that displays before and during item use (if the item is usable)
- Attribute bonuses and penalties
- Optional nerve/stress relief effects

Equipment

Equipment in THMastery can be worn or carried in specific slots: Head, Face, Outfit, Hands, and Trinket. Each item provides unique attribute modifiers that can enhance or penalize your character's abilities. Equipment for the head, face and outfit slot is visually displayed on the character model when equipped. Equipment only affects up to 4 different types of attributes to avoid confusion. Additional points beyond this should be negated by negative points.

All attribute changes are applied instantly when equipping or unequipping items. Multiple items can be combined to create specialized character builds, but only one item per slot can be equipped at a time.



Equipment bonuses generally follow the following logical rules:

- Athletics: Given to items that influence movement or are worn by athletic professions
- Dexterity: Given to items that influence arm/finger movement or are worn by dexterous professions
- Perception: Given to items that influence any kind of perception(e.g., hearing or eyesight) or are worn by perceptive professions
- Persuasion: Given to items that look cool or make the wearer seem nice
- Bluff: Given to costumes, items that hide parts of body, or items worn by professions known for omitting truth
- Intimidation: Given to items that make the wearer look more or less intimidating
- Knowledge: Given to items that make one look smart or are associated with smart professions
- Will: Given to comfortable or protective items
- Creativity: Given to colorful or quirky items

- Luck: Given to items associated with luck/lucky events or obscure things

Equally penalties are applied in the same style:

- Athletics: Penalties should be given to items that hinder movement or are typically worn by individuals with a sedentary lifestyle.
- Dexterity: Applied to items that restrict finger or arm movement, such as bulky gloves or rigid armor.
- Perception: Given to items that obstruct vision, hearing, or other sensory functions (e.g., sunglasses in dim light, heavy helmets).
- Persuasion: Applied to items that make the wearer appear unkempt, strange, or otherwise unapproachable.
- Bluff: Given to items that draw unnecessary attention, revealing rather than concealing features (e.g., overly flashy costumes).
- Intimidation: Applied to items that make the wearer look less imposing, such as childish or goofy clothing.
- Knowledge: Given to items that make one appear less intelligent, confused, or distracted (e.g., disorganized notes, absurd headgear).
- Will: Penalties should be assigned to uncomfortable or distracting items that make it harder to concentrate or feel secure.
- Creativity: Applied to bland, uniform, or restrictive items that discourage self-expression.
- Luck: Given to items associated with misfortune or unlucky events (e.g., broken mirrors, black cats in folklore, or clumsy shoes).



Face Clothing

Facial accessories are worn on a character's face, providing various attribute modifications. Vision enhancements, disguises, and protective gear can be found in this category, with each item being capable of altering perception and social dynamics.

Item Name	Description	Bonuses	Penalties
Fake Mustache	A fake mustache. The perfect disguise. Nobody will recognise you. Looks especially good if you already have a mustache.	+1 Bluff	-1 Perception
Frameless Glasses	Enhances your... wait these aren't real. At least they make you look smart.	+1 Knowledge	-1 Athletics
Glasses	Strongly frames glasses. Enhances your vision. Not covered by health insurance for some reason.	+2 Perception	-1 Athletics
Medical Mask	A personal protective item that is used by healthcare professionals, serving as a	+1 Bluff, +1 Will	-2 Perception

Item Name	Description	Bonuses	Penalties
	mechanical barrier for airborne transmission of pathogens. Can also be worn by the entire world.		
Monocle	Enhances your vision... on one eye. These things are a rare sight nowadays. Time to bring them back!	+1 Perception, +1 Luck	-1 Athletics



Hats

A wide variety of hats and head coverings can be discovered throughout the game. Professional, casual, and novelty headwear are represented, with each piece being distinguished by its unique combination of advantages and disadvantages.

Item Name	Description	Bonuses	Penalties
Bataclava	Perfect for ski trips or questionable life choices. Bank visits not recommended.	+2 Intimidation	None
Beanie	Keeps your head warm and your style lukewarm. At least your ears won't freeze.	+1 Athletics, +1 Intimidation	-1 Perception
Bolt Hat	Makes you look like a walking DIY project. Great conversation starter, terrible first date choice.	+1 Bluff, +1 Intimidation, +1 Creativity	-2 Knowledge
Brain Hat	Your thoughts are literally spilling out. Perfect for psychology majors with a sense of humor.	+1 Bluff, +2 Intimidation, +1 Creativity	-3 Knowledge
Chef's Hat	Somehow makes anything you cook taste better. Results may vary with instant noodles.	+2 Dexterity	None
Detective Hat	Doesn't actually solve mysteries, but makes you look qualified to try.	+2 Knowledge	None
Dino Cap	Because adulting is overrated. Roaring noises not included but strongly encouraged.	+3 Creativity, +1 Luck	-2 Intimidation
Party Cone	The universal symbol for "I was invited!" Whether that's true or not is irrelevant.	+1 Creativity, +3 Luck	-1 Intimidation, -1 Knowledge

Item Name	Description	Bonuses	Penalties
Pink Beanie	Like the regular beanie but with a splash of "notice me." Mission accomplished.	+2 Creativity, +1 Luck	-1 Perception, -1 Intimidation
Police Hat	Comes with a built-in authority complex. Real officers remain unimpressed.	+1 Intimidation, +1 Will	-1 Persuasion
Snapback	Wearing it forward is optional, being cool is mandatory.	+1 Perception, +1 Persuasion	None
Scout's Hat	Has more badges than you've earned but who's counting?	+1 Will	None
Worker Helmet	OSHA approved. Mom approved. Fashion police still deliberating.	+2 Will	None

Design Rules:

- Professional hats (Chef's Hat, Detective Hat, Worker Helmet) provide single focused bonuses without penalties
- Costume/novelty hats provide larger bonuses with significant penalties
- Maximum bonus for a single attribute is +3
- Multiple bonuses typically come with at least one penalty
- Penalties are proportional to the total bonus value
- Hats tied to professions provide bonuses that match their role



Outfits

The largest variety of attribute modifications can be found in the outfit category. Professional attire, casual wear, and specialized costumes are included, with each piece being designed to significantly influence a character's capabilities and social presence.

I'll create the complete outfit table with new humorous descriptions while keeping all effects the same.

Item Name	Description	Bonuses	Penalties
Apron	Protection from food stains, customer complaints not covered.	+2 Will	None
Bikini	Bold fashion choice for a university. Even bolder in winter.	+3 Athletics	-2 Bluff
Black Suit	When you need to look professional, mysterious, or professionally mysterious.	+3 Persuasion, +1 Bluff, +1 Intimidation	-2 Athletics, -1 Dexterity

Item Name	Description	Bonuses	Penalties
Blue Hoodie	The unofficial uniform of students everywhere. Bonus pockets for snacks.	+1 Persuasion, +1 Will	None
Blue Shirt	The safest choice in your wardrobe. Impossible to look bad in, impossible to look great in.	+1 Athletics, +1 Will	None
Blue Suit	For when you want to look successful but your bank account disagrees.	+2 Persuasion, +3 Bluff	-2 Athletics, -1 Dexterity
Bridal Dress	Perfect for weddings, dramatic entrances, or really confusing your classmates.	+2 Persuasion, +2 Luck	-3 Athletics
Butcher's Outfit	Surprisingly clean for a butcher's outfit. Suspiciously clean, actually...	+1 Athletics, +1 Intimidation	-1 Persuasion
Button-down Shirt	The shirt that says "I have a presentation today but I'm not happy about it."	+2 Knowledge	-1 Creativity
Charro	Turns every entrance into a potential mariachi moment.	+1 Athletics, +1 Creativity	None
Chef's Outfit	Wearing this doesn't make your instant noodles taste better. We checked.	+2 Dexterity, +1 Creativity	None
Doctor's Coat	Not a real doctor, but plays one in student theater.	+2 Knowledge	None
Jogging Suit	For when you want people to think you might exercise at any moment.	+2 Athletics	-1 Persuasion
Kimono	Beautiful, traditional, and impossible to put on correctly without help.	+1 Will, +1 Creativity	None
Leather Jacket	Made from 100% fake leather. Just like your bad boy attitude.	+2 Persuasion, +1 Intimidation	-1 Dexterity
Pajamas	Technically not appropriate for lectures, but who's brave enough to tell you?	+2 Will	None
Purple Shirt	It's purple. That's it. That's the description.	+1 Athletics	None
Quirky Poncho	When you want to make a statement but aren't sure what that statement is.	+3 Creativity	-1 Dexterity

Item Name	Description	Bonuses	Penalties
Rags	Somehow worse than wearing nothing. Fashion police have issued a warrant.	None	-1 Athletics, -1 Dexterity, -1 Persuasion, -1 Will
Red Shirt	Makes you go faster. Or was that just in that racing game?	+1 Athletics, +1 Intimidation	None
Scout's Outfit	Has more pockets than you have things to put in them.	+1 Athletics, +1 Dexterity, +1 Perception	-1 Persuasion, -1 Intimidation
Scrubs	"Not that kind of doctor" - your response to medical emergencies.	+1 Knowledge	None
Sky Sweater	Van Gogh would be proud. Or confused. Probably confused.	+2 Creativity	-1 Bluff
Sweatshirt Jacket	The perfect blend of "I tried" and "but not too hard."	+1 Athletics, +1 Will	None
Swimming Trunks	Appropriate for pools, beaches, and absolutely nowhere else.	+3 Athletics	-2 Bluff
Trenchcoat	Contains either too many secrets or too many snacks. No in-between.	+3 Bluff	-1 Athletics
Worker Jacket	Has that "just came from honest work" look, even if you didn't.	+2 Will	-1 Bluff

Design Rules:

- Maximum single attribute bonus is +3
- Professional outfits provide focused bonuses matching their profession
- Multiple significant bonuses (+2 or higher) always come with penalties
- Only one item (Rags) has purely negative effects
- Specialized clothing (swimming, formal) has more extreme trade-offs

Trinkets

Small personal items and accessories can be equipped as trinkets. While their individual effects are subtle, these items generally don’t offer drawbacks.

Item Name	Description	Bonuses	Penalties
Lucky 8 Ball	A nice lucky 8 ball. Carrying it around will certainly bring luck.	+1 Luck	None
Pen	A regular pen with a tiny logo printed on it.	+1 Creativity	None
Calculator Watch	Your father said it would be useful in real life. For once, he wasn't wrong.	+1 Knowledge	None
Student ID Card	A piece of plastic proving you belong here. The photo looks nothing like you anymore.	+1 Persuasion	None
USB Flash Drive	Contains your entire academic career. Better not lose this one like the last three.	+1 Will	None
Library Card	So worn out the librarian needs to scan it five times. Worth it for the free printing.	+1 Knowledge	None
Friendship Bracelet	Made during that one boring lecture. At least you learned something that day.	+1 Persuasion	None
Energy Drink Keychain	A trophy from your longest all-nighter. The caffeine might still be in there.	+1 Athletics	None
Lucky Dice	A D20 that only rolls high during practice rolls. Every tabletop gamer's curse.	+1 Luck	None
Smartwatch	Counts your steps to class and judges you for taking the elevator.	+1 Perception	None
Stress Ball	Previous owner clearly had more stress - it's more oval now.	+1 Will	None
Bottle Opener	"For opening bottles of water," you told your mom. Technically not a lie.	+1 Bluff	None

Design Rules

- Limited to +1 bonus for any attribute
- No penalties on trinkets
- Effects should logically match the item's purpose



Hand-Held Items

Items that are regularly held in the hand such as tools or other equipment.

Item Name	Description	Bonuses	Penalties
Coffee Mug	The fourth one this week. This time you'll remember where you left it. Probably.	+1 Will, +1 Knowledge	-1 Dexterity
Textbook	"Lightly used" according to the store. The coffee stains add character.	+2 Knowledge	-1 Athletics
Tablet Device	Battery life measured in minutes. At least the cat videos look crisp.	+1 Knowledge, +1 Creativity	-1 Will
Stress Ball	Nine out of ten doctors recommend squeezing this instead of your classmates.	+2 Will	-1 Knowledge
Smartphone	Latest model. Could pay rent instead, but priorities are priorities.	+1 Perception, +1 Bluff	-1 Will
Lab Equipment	Delicate instruments that cost more than your entire education. No pressure.	+2 Dexterity	-1 Creativity
Gaming Controller	The reason your grades started social distancing.	+2 Dexterity, +1 Creativity	-2 Persuasion
Student Notes	Hieroglyphics would be easier to decipher.	+1 Knowledge, +1 Will	-1 Athletics
Sports Equipment	For when you remember there's life outside the library.	+2 Athletics	-1 Knowledge
Swiss Army Knife	Has everything except what you need right now.	+1 Dexterity, +1 Knowledge	-1 Persuasion
Umbrella	Because checking the weather app is too much work.	+1 Will, +1 Perception	-1 Athletics
First Aid Kit	For paper cuts and existential crises. Results may vary.	+2 Will	-1 Athletics
Flashlight	Perfect for late-night study sessions and impromptu ghost stories.	+2 Perception	-1 Bluff
Tool Box	Contains solutions to problems you didn't know you had.	+2 Dexterity, +1 Knowledge	-2 Athletics
Plunger	The unsung hero of student housing. Handle with pride.	+1 Athletics, +1 Will	-1 Persuasion

Item Name	Description	Bonuses	Penalties
Lock Picks	"For educational purposes only." Sure.	+2 Dexterity, +1 Bluff	-2 Will
Extension Cord	The most popular person in any lecture hall.	+1 Knowledge, +1 Creativity	-1 Athletics
Safety Gloves	Because some mistakes you only make once.	+1 Will, +1 Athletics	-1 Persuasion

Design Rules:

- Maximum bonus of +2 for primary attributes
- Items with multiple bonuses require at least one penalty
- More powerful combinations have stronger penalties

Food

Food items in THMastery can be consumed to receive temporary attribute modifications. A character's metabolism can only process one food item at a time, functioning similarly to an equipment slot. When a food item is consumed, its effects are applied immediately and persist until they are cleared. The food slot automatically clears when the character sleeps or at the end of the day, at which point all active food effects are removed. If a second food item is consumed while another is still active, the new item's effects replace those of the previous item. Unlike equipment, food items are permanently removed from the player's inventory upon consumption, requiring new items to be acquired if their effects are desired again.

Food Categories:

- Category A: Premium meals and specialty items with powerful effects
- Category B: Common foods with moderate, focused benefits
- Category C: Basic consumables with limited impact



Category A

Category A food items represent premium consumables with powerful attribute modifications and significant stress relief effects. These high-quality meals and desserts often provide multiple substantial bonuses, though some may come with minor drawbacks.

Item Name	Description	Bonuses	Penalties	Stress Relief
Banana Cake	Banana in every bite. No monkey business here.	+1 Will, +2 Creativity, +1 Luck	-1 Athletics	+3
Birthday Cake	Perfect for celebrations or last-minute apologies. Candles sold separately.	+1 Bluff, +2 Creativity, +3 Luck	-1 Athletics, -1 Intimidation	+3
Chocolate Cake	The cure for bad days, broken hearts, and boring parties.	+3 Bluff, +1 Luck	-1 Athletics, -1 Creativity	+4
Decorative Cake	So beautiful it feels wrong to eat it. But you will.	+1 Persuasion, +3 Creativity, +2 Luck	-1 Athletics	+3
Döner Kebab	A feast wrapped in bread. Best consumed at 2 AM outside a club.	+3 Persuasion, +1 Luck	None	+1
Healthy Meal	Proof you're trying to be an adult. Your body says thanks, your taste buds, not so much.	+3 Athletics, +2 Dexterity, +1 Perception, +1 Persuasion, +1 Knowledge	None	0
Hearty Meal	Spicy enough to remind you why water is important.	+1 Dexterity, +4 Intimidation, +2 Will	-1 Perception, -1 Knowledge	-1
Omelette	The only thing standing between you and starvation at 7 AM.	+1 Athletics, +2 Dexterity, +1 Knowledge	None	0
Skewers	Tiny swords with meat and veggies. A balanced attack on hunger.	+1 Dexterity, +2 Intimidation, +2 Creativity	None	0
Strawberry Cake	A pink paradise that dares to be both fruity and fluffy.	+3 Persuasion, +1 Creativity, +1 Luck	-1 Athletics	0

Design Rules:

- Provides multiple substantial bonuses
- May include significant penalties for powerful effects
- Often includes stress relief benefits
- Represents complete meals and specialty desserts
- Higher-quality items with more complex effects



Category B

Category B food items consist of basic but nutritious foods that provide focused attribute bonuses. While less powerful than Category A items, these common foods offer specific advantages with minimal drawbacks.

Item Name	Description	Bonuses	Penalties	Stress Relief
Apple	A nice red apple. Might keep the doctor away.	+1 Athletics, +1 Knowledge	None	0
Bread	Germany's favorite food and mascot.	+1 Athletics, +1 Dexterity	-1 Creativity	0
Carrot	Crunchy, orange, and full of sass. Bugs Bunny approved.	+1 Perception, +1 Athletics	None	0
Cheese	A wheel of cheese that's sharper than your wit and just as cultured.	+2 Knowledge	-1 Athletics	+1
Chili	Hot enough to make you regret your choices, but worth it.	+2 Will, +1 Intimidation	-1 Dexterity	0
Pineapple	Spiky outside, sweet inside. A metaphor for life.	+2 Creativity, +1 Luck	-1 Athletics	+1
Plum	Small, sweet, and so underrated it should have its own fan club.	+1 Dexterity, +1 Creativity	None	+1

Design Rules

- Focused on single strong bonuses (+2)
- Limited penalties if any
- Moderate stress relief on select items
- Represents common but nutritious foods
- Effects match real-world properties



Category C

Category C food items represent the most basic consumable options, often consisting of processed foods, condiments, and raw ingredients. These items typically provide minimal benefits or may even carry penalties, reflecting their lower quality or incomplete preparation.

Item Name	Description	Bonuses	Penalties	Stress Relief
Canned Corn	Convenient corn in a can. Perfect for culinary emergencies.	+1 Knowledge	-1 Athletics	0
Cereal	Sugary shapes that make mornings a little less miserable.	+2 Creativity	-1 Perception	0
Cornflakes	Crispy, tasteless bits that sound like a breakfast idea.	+1 Perception	None	0
Ketchup	Liquid gold for fries, burgers, and questionable pasta.	+1 Persuasion	-1 Dexterity	0
Canned Mushrooms	Mushrooms preserved for the apocalypse, or dinner.	+1 Knowledge, +1 Creativity	-1 Athletics, -1 Luck	0
Mustard	A bold companion to elevate even the saddest hot dog.	+1 Intimidation	None	0
Raw Steak	Uncooked beef with endless potential and questionable safety.	+2 Athletics	-1 Knowledge	0
Toast	A crunchy canvas for butter, jam, or existential dread.	+1 Dexterity, +1 Perception	-1 Creativity	0

Design Rules:

- Limited to small bonuses (+1)
- May include offsetting penalties
- No stress relief benefits
- Represents basic ingredients and processed foods
- Simple, straightforward effects

Temporary Items

Unlike equipment or food items, temporary items provide attribute modifications for a limited duration measured in seconds. These items can be consumed to receive immediate effects that wear off after their specified duration. Multiple temporary items can be active simultaneously, with no limit to the number of concurrent effects. Each item's effects are tracked independently, allowing for strategic combinations of different bonuses.

When a temporary item is consumed, it is removed from the inventory and its timer begins immediately. The effects persist until the duration expires, at which point the attribute modifications are automatically removed. Using multiple items of the same type does not extend the duration; instead, it creates a new independent effect timer. The timer of temporary items is not connected to the ingame time and instead based on real-world seconds.

Temporary items often represent quick-acting consumables that provide immediate but fleeting benefits, making them particularly useful for specific challenges or time-sensitive situations.

Item Name	Description	Duration (s)	Bonuses	Penalties	Stress Relief
Coffee	A fine smelling delight for the casual tired student.	180	+1 Athletics	-1 Dexterity	+1
Energy Shot	Like coffee's aggressive cousin. May cause time travel.	180	+2 Athletics, +1 Will	-2 Creativity	0
Throat Lozenges	Tastes like medicine trying to be candy and failing.	300	+2 Persuasion	-1 Creativity	+1
Focus Pills	"Definitely just vitamins," you tell your parents.	240	+2 Knowledge, +1 Perception	-1 Athletics	-1
Chewing Gum	The only thing keeping you awake during statistics.	120	+1 Will, +1 Perception	None	+1
Caffeinated Mints	Because why should your breath suffer for your deadlines?	180	+1 Persuasion, +1 Athletics	-1 Will	0
Pain Relief	For headaches and group project meetings.	360	+2 Will	-1 Perception	+2

Item Name	Description	Duration (s)	Bonuses	Penalties	Stress Relief
Cold Pack	Instant regret when applied directly to the forehead.	240	+1 Perception, +1 Will	None	+1
Sugar Rush	Pure glucose. Your dentist disapproves.	120	+2 Athletics, +1 Creativity	-2 Knowledge	-1
Breathing Exercise	Free, but requires actually remembering to do it.	300	+1 Will	None	+2

Design Rules
- Effects last for specific durations (typically 120-360 seconds)
- Stronger effects typically have shorter durations
- Items often provide stress relief or stress penalty
- Significant bonuses (+2) usually come with penalties
- Effects should make logical sense for the item

Miscellaneous Items

Miscellaneous items serve as essential tools for world interaction and task progression rather than providing direct attribute modifications. Unlike equipment or consumables, these items have no inherent statistical benefits but instead unlock new possibilities through their specific functions and uses.

These items fall into three distinct sub categories:

- Task Items: Objects required for completing specific tasks or advancing storylines
- Access Tools: Items that unlock new areas or grant permissions
- Readable Items: Documents containing information, lore, or task-relevant details

Miscellaneous items cannot be consumed or equipped in traditional slots. Instead, their use is context-sensitive, triggering specific interactions when used in the correct location or situation. While these items occupy inventory space, they typically cannot be discarded until their purpose has been fulfilled.

Some miscellaneous items, particularly readable ones, can be examined to reveal additional text or information. This examination can provide crucial hints, story details, or task instructions that may be necessary for progression.

Item Name	Description	Sub Category	Special Function
Book	That book everyone claims to have read but nobody actually has.	Readable	Contains tutorial text about reading that can be viewed
Flyer	Yet another flyer you'll probably keep in your bag until it becomes archaeological evidence.	Readable	Contains course information about SMS
List	A list that probably contains important things. Probably. Can't read your own handwriting though.	Readable	Can be viewed for task information
Master Key	Opens everything except your future. Use responsibly, or don't - we're not your parents.	Access	Opens multiple locked doors
Paper	A blank canvas for your thoughts, or more realistically, doodles during lectures.	Task Item	Can be used in various tasks
Plunger	The kind of emergency equipment you never think you need until you desperately do.	Task Item	Used for specific maintenance tasks
Present	A mysterious box that follows the age-old tradition of reusing gift wrap.	Task Item	Can be opened to reveal it's empty
Worksite Key	The key to places you probably shouldn't be. Perfect for "supervised" exploring.	Access	Opens worksite area
Library Card	Somehow expired before you got it. The librarian is judging you.	Access	Grants library access
Student Records	If anyone asks, you're doing "research." That's your story and you're sticking to it.	Task Item	Used in administrative tasks
WiFi Password	Written on the back of a receipt from 2019. Still works, surprisingly.	Task Item	Provides network access
Lost Phone	The owner's probably still looking for it. 47 missed calls from "Mom."	Task Item	Contains useful messages
Class Schedule	Coffee stains make Tuesday unreadable. Maybe that means no classes? Worth a try.	Readable	Shows course times

Item Name	Description	Sub Category	Special Function
Building Map	Shows everything except where you currently are. Every time. Without fail.	Readable	Reveals location names
Maintenance Report	More coffee stains. This campus runs on caffeine and duct tape.	Readable	Contains repair information

Economy

THMastery uses the Euro (€) as its in-game currency, maintaining real-world value equivalence to help players intuitively understand item worth. For example, a coffee costs 2-3€, while books run for 20-60€, mirroring real-world pricing.

Players can acquire Euros through multiple channels:

- Task completion rewards
- Environmental discoveries (finding money in the world)
- NPC interactions and gifts
- Selling items to vendors

Vendors

A vendor is an NPC who sells or sometimes buys items from the player, operating from a fixed location like a shop or stall. The game features a dynamic vendor system where prices vary between different merchants. Unlike many games, items don't have fixed values - the same item might be sold for different prices at different locations. For instance, a used textbook might have a higher price at the campus bookstore than at a general shop.

While all vendors sell items, only some vendors will buy items from players, and those that do often specialize in specific categories - for example, the IT department's shop only purchases computer parts, while the campus bookstore exclusively buys and sells academic materials.

Collectors

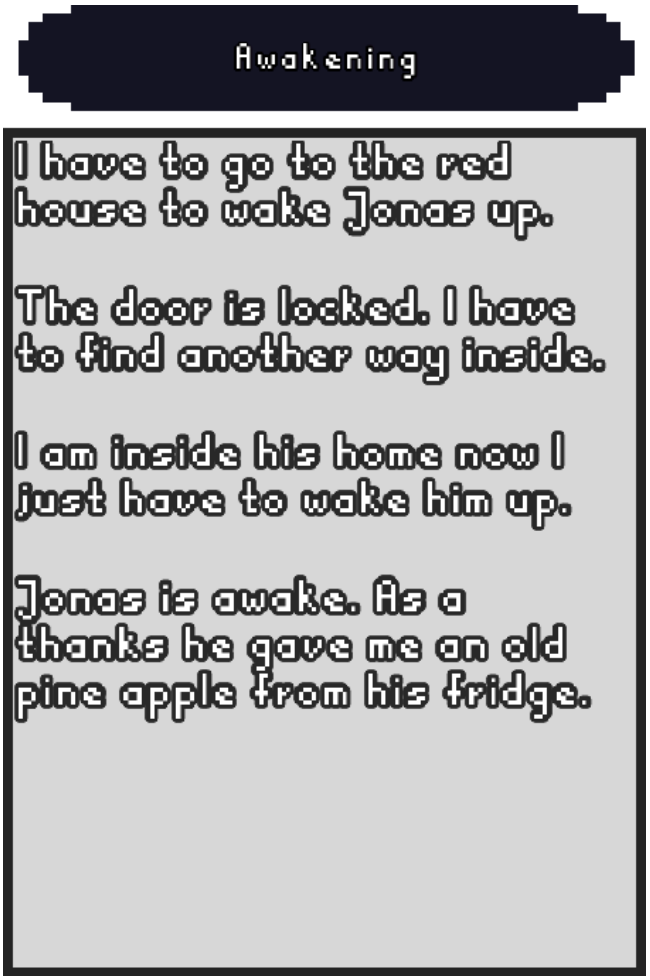
Another part of THMastery's economy is its collector system. Throughout the campus, certain NPCs act as specialized collectors. Unlike regular vendors, collectors will accept unlimited quantities of specific items, offering either better prices than standard vendors or providing increased affinity with important NPCs and factions from the main storyline. Most importantly, collectors create value from otherwise unsellable items - things that regular vendors won't accept can often find a home with a collector, transforming seemingly worthless objects into desirable finds. This encourages players to look more carefully at items they might otherwise ignore, as that piece of apparently useless junk could be exactly what a particular collector wants. For example, while info flyers hold relevant information when read for the first time, collecting multiple of this readable item serves no gameplay purpose. This is sold by the collector named flyer girl in the entrance of A10 giving one euro per flyer.

Objectives

Objectives represent the many to-do's in THMastery's world. These range from simple interactions in the form of Activities to full-blown task-chains.

Tasks

Tasks are what other games typically call quests - assignments given to players by NPCs through dialogue. Players can complete most tasks in multiple ways, allowing them to leverage different attributes and skills. While one player might solve a problem through persuasion, another might use technical knowledge, and a third might discover an entirely different approach through exploration.



The game tracks both current objectives and completed steps in the player's journal, allowing players to review their progress and past decisions at any time

For main narrative tasks, the game always provides a solution that doesn't require skill checks, ensuring all players can progress through the story. However, these fail-safe paths intentionally offer less satisfying conclusions or reduced rewards compared to solutions requiring specialized skills. Optional side tasks and non-introductory courses don't need these fail-safe options, meaning some content may be impossible for certain character builds to complete.

Task rewards are deeply tied to narrative context. Money is only awarded when it makes sense within the story - a professor might pay for research assistance, but a student wouldn't offer cash for finding their notebook. Experience points are awarded based on task length and complexity, with full task chains typically providing enough experience to earn one attribute point. Items as rewards must fit the context naturally, maintaining the game's realistic university setting. When completing tasks, players gain affinity with both individual NPCs and their associated factions, with the amount determined by the task's narrative significance and whether it involved meaningful choices.

As players progress through tasks, they face narrative choices that affect both the story and their rewards. These decisions often focus on moral, philosophical, or political questions. When tasks present morally questionable options, they balance negative story consequences with gameplay benefits - for instance, choosing an "evil" path might damage relationships but

provide powerful items or resources, making all choices viable from both roleplaying and gameplay perspectives.

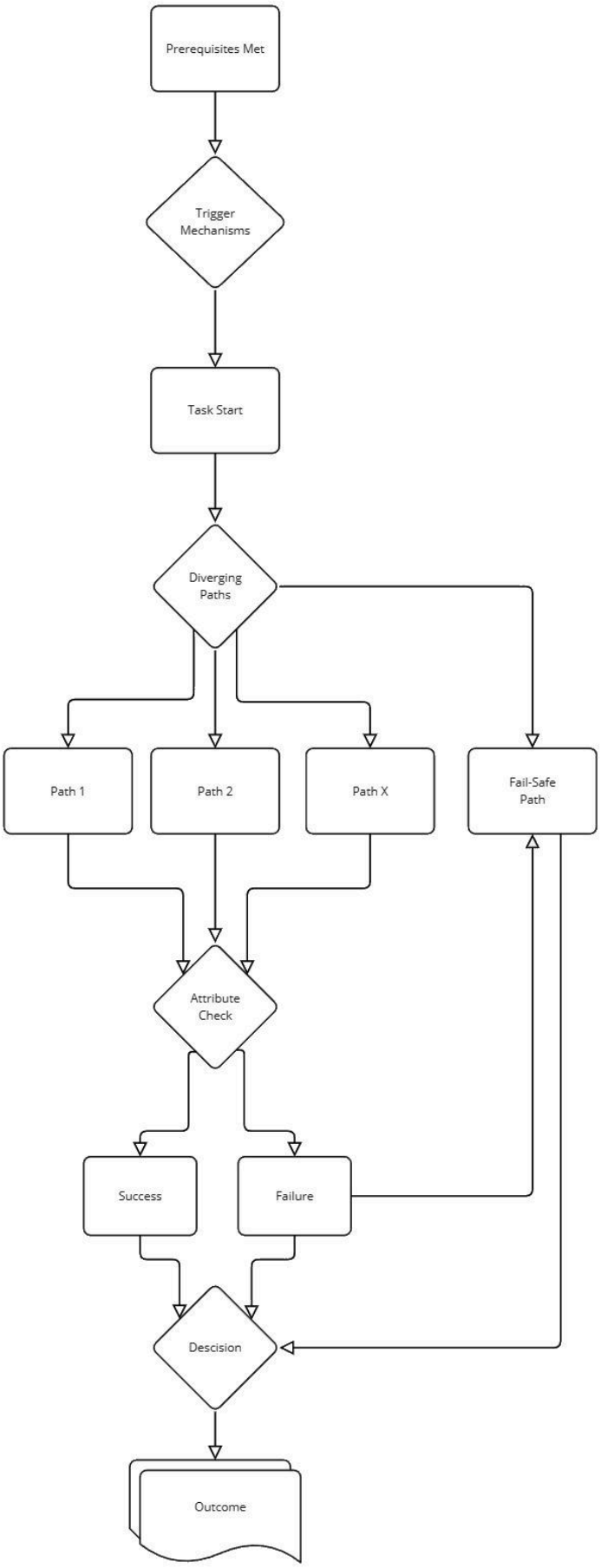
Task Structure

Tasks begin in one of two ways once prerequisites are met: either through a direct dialogue with an NPC (Direct Dialogue Trigger) or by encountering/interacting with something in the environment (Indirect Environmental Trigger). Both trigger types lead to the formal task start.

Once started, the task presents multiple solution paths. Each path typically leads to an attribute check possibly being the same, though some paths may bypass checks entirely. Success at these checks allows for the task to progress, but neither necessarily ends the task - instead, both lead to a decision point.

At the decision point, players make choices that affect the final outcome. What decisions are available depends on the chosen. The outcome may vary significantly based on the outcome of the task challenge meaning the combination of the chosen path, check results, and final decision. Multiple outcomes are possible for each task, represented by the stacked outcome cards at the bottom of the diagram.

This offers a general overview of the structure of tasks on a macro level view. Tasks can vary base but all can be roughly boiled down to this formula. On a more specified level the contents of a task can be categorized by task challenges.



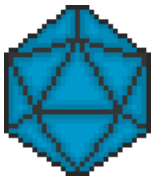
Task Challenges

Since THMastery doesn't include combat, tasks are built around different types of challenges that serve as core building blocks for gameplay. Each task typically focuses on one primary challenge type, with task chains incorporating various challenges to maintain engagement and prevent repetition.

Tasks are composed of these challenges, which in turn combine multiple basic gameplay mechanics (exploring, fetching, interacting, dialogue, and checks) into meaningful narrative scenarios. For example, while picking up an item and delivering it elsewhere is a basic fetching mechanic, a challenge wraps this in context - perhaps retrieving a confidential document requires exploring to find the right office, interacting with a locked drawer, and using dialogue to convince a suspicious secretary. These fundamental mechanics are:

- Exploration involves navigating and understanding the environment
- Fetching requires acquiring and delivering items
- Interaction presents contextual options that change the state of objects or the environment
- Dialogue involves navigating branched conversations with NPCs
- Checks test character attributes to determine success or failure

The challenges in the game are:



The Big Check

Design: This challenge centers around a single attribute check with difficulty significantly above the current game stage's norm. While only highly specialized characters can pass it directly, the challenge provides multiple ways to reduce its difficulty through smaller activities. This system provides an organic fail-safe path - players with low attributes can still succeed by gathering enough assistance, though at a cost.

Example: A course assignment features a difficult knowledge check. Players can gather tips from other students or consult reference materials, with each helping activity reducing the check's difficulty. However, getting these tips requires spending money or trading favors, making success possible but costly for non-specialized characters.



The Road Block

Design: Players face a clear physical obstacle blocking their path to an objective. Rather than relying on skill checks alone, the challenge emphasizes environmental exploration to discover multiple viable solutions. Success comes from thoroughly investigating the environment to find different approaches, with fail-safe options naturally integrated into the setting.

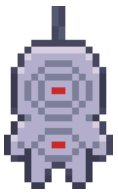
Example: When tasked with accessing a restricted warehouse, players might find a climbable window in the back, attempt to persuade the front guard, or discover a route through connected maintenance tunnels. Fail-safe options appear naturally - finding a rope to assist with climbing or accumulating enough money to bribe the guard.



The Mystery

Design: Mysteries derive their difficulty from abstraction and investigation. Players receive a clear goal but must piece together how to achieve it using their knowledge of the game world and its inhabitants. Success relies on thorough exploration and understanding of the game's social networks and available resources.

Example: An NPC requests a specific cake. Players must investigate potential sources by gathering information about bakers, finding recipes and ingredients, or discovering someone who already has access to such cakes. The solution emerges from understanding and utilizing the game world's interconnected systems.



The Encounter

Design: Serving as THMastery's version of a boss fight, encounters are structured social challenges initiated through marked dialogue options. While small encounters revolve around a single check, major encounters may require multiple successful checks. The player's dialogue choices throughout the encounter affect the difficulty of the final check, with passive attribute checks providing strategic advice. The type of check determines the correct approach:

- Persuasion encounters require selecting logically sound arguments
- Bluff encounters need consistent, believable deceptions
- Intimidation encounters demand appropriately threatening responses

Beyond social scenarios, this structure also applies to technical challenges like crafting or problem-solving, where step-by-step decision-making determines success in a single conversation instance.

Example: When trying to convince a professor to extend a deadline, players might engage in a persuasive encounter. Each dialogue choice either strengthens or weakens their final argument, with their knowledge attribute passively suggesting valid academic reasons for the extension.



The Action Piece

Design: These challenges represent high-stakes, fast-paced scenarios where time nominally pressures the player but freezes during decision-making. Each available option triggers an attribute check representing a specific action, creating a sequence of dramatic choices without real-time pressure.

Example: During an escape sequence, players might face a series of parkour-style choices through campus, or in the inner mind space, engage in a visualized conflict where each decision represents a different tactical approach.



The Quiz

Design: This straightforward challenge tests the player's knowledge of previously presented information. The required information is always available beforehand

through various means, making preparation and attention key to success rather than character attributes.

Example: Players might face a quiz where the answers can be found through prior conversations with NPCs, documents scattered throughout the relevant area, or a preceding lecture presentation. Success depends on having gathered and retained the right information.



The Production

Design: This multi-step challenge involves transforming items through a series of decisions, where each step offers multiple options. Unlike encounter-style challenges, success isn't determined by checks but by the combination of choices made. The challenge combines elements of mystery (gathering necessary components and tools) with structured decision-making. Different combinations of choices can unlock hidden options, encouraging experimentation.

Example: When crafting coffee for two people with different preferences, players progress through multiple steps - grinding, brewing, and adding ingredients. Each step offers options favoring either recipient's taste. A hidden "compromise" solution emerges by combining certain choices and adding cinnamon, offering a unique reward by satisfying both preferences partially.



The Preparation

Design: This challenge focuses on managing multiple preparations for a future event, where each choice affects various outcome scores and consumes limited time. Unlike single-check challenges, success is measured across multiple criteria, with choices enhancing some aspects while potentially conflicting with others. The time limit forces strategic prioritization, making perfect scores in all categories impossible.

Example: When organizing a party, players must balance three aspects: Atmosphere, Guest Satisfaction, and Social Dynamics. Each decision affects multiple aspects - formal decorations improve atmosphere but require matching refreshments; casual snacks boost guest satisfaction but clash with formal settings; the guest list affects social dynamics but influences refreshment needs; music must match the party's style. Time limits force strategic choices between these interconnected elements.



The Puzzle

Design: These challenges require manipulating interactive objects to achieve specific states or configurations. Solutions might involve spatial arrangements, item placement, or changing object states based on textual clues or logical requirements.

Example: A security system puzzle might require arranging circuit components in the correct order, or a historical puzzle might involve rotating museum artifacts to match a pattern described in an ancient text.

Activities

Unlike formal tasks, activities are discoverable interactions woven into the environment that don't appear in the task menu. These opportunities arise naturally as players explore the game world, presenting themselves through environmental cues rather than explicit NPC direction.

Activities remain self-contained, offering immediate outcomes without branching choices or larger narrative implications. For example, players might discover a birthday party in progress and realize they can either trade a gift for information about a special cake, or attempt to steal the cake directly. Similarly, they might find a locked door with visible rewards inside, prompting them to search the area for a key. These situations reward observant players with immediate benefits while maintaining the game world's organic feel.

Example Task Chains

Basics of Web-Based Programming

Starting Point: Professor Turing, a laid-back yet highly knowledgeable IT professor, introduces students to the basics of web-based programming. The course is presented as a task chain to complete a simple yet challenging web application.

Task Trigger

- Prerequisites: None
- Trigger: Triggered by attending Professor Turing's first lecture in the computer lab.

Task 1: Create a Basic HTML Structure (The big check)

Option 1: Use Knowledge (Difficulty: 15) to write a clean and functional HTML structure directly in the computer lab. The difficulty of this check can be reduced by gathering snippets of HTML code from various sources, each one lowering the difficulty by 3:

- Snippet 1 (Web Search): Use the lab's internet browser to search for relevant HTML examples. Requires a simple Perception check (Difficulty: 5) to identify usable information from the search results.
- Snippet 2 (Snack Bribe): One student, Alex, has a critical snippet but refuses to share it without a bag of chips.
- Snippet 3 (Teacher's Hint): During a dialogue with Professor Turing, choose the correct conversational options to demonstrate genuine interest in web development. Discuss the importance of clean code structure and share an insightful observation about the professor's lecture. Success leads to the professor sharing a key HTML snippet as an example.
- Snippet 4 (Theft): Another student, Riley, has written a snippet on a piece of paper. Riley refuses to share it, so the player can attempt to steal it from their desk. Requires a Dexterity check (Difficulty: 9) or a successful distraction setup using the nearby broken printer.
- Snippet 5 (Buy an HTML Guide): Visit the THM campus store and purchase a book on HTML basics. This book contains the final snippet required to reduce the difficulty of the HTML structure check.

Option 2: Riley, a skilled coding student, has already completed the HTML code but refuses to share it, stating that she doesn't need assistance. However, it becomes evident that Riley is struggling with the design aspect of her website. The player can unlock the hidden Creativity check (Difficulty: 8) to design the website layout for Riley and obtain the snippet in exchange. To realize Riley needs help with design, the player must:

- Inspect Papers: Examine a pile of notes and drafts near Riley's workstation. This reveals messy, half-finished designs and highlights her difficulties with layouts, unlocking the dialogue option to offer help.
- Hint from a Peer: Speak with another student in the course who casually mentions that "Riley's great at coding but her designs are always a mess."

Task 2: Add Interactivity with JavaScript (The action piece)

Inner Mind Simulation

The professor presents debugging as a "battle against the bugs," triggering a visualization in the inner mind. The player is transported to a military base under attack by strange alien bugs representing code errors. The task unfolds as follows:

Combat System:

- Engage in turn-based faux JRPG combat using the dialogue system.
- Each action corresponds to a check. The difficulty of the checks varies based on the type of bug being fought, with more advanced bugs presenting more difficult checks:
    - Knowledge (Targeted Attacks): Use logic and programming expertise to execute precise, high-damage actions against specific weaknesses in the "bugs."
    - Dexterity (Precision Shots): Apply technical finesse to quickly resolve minor threats or interruptions.
    - Perception (Hidden Weaknesses): Analyze the battlefield or enemy behavior to discover vulnerabilities, reducing the difficulty of subsequent checks or exposing critical points.
    - Creativity (Special Maneuvers): Improvise unconventional attacks or utilize the environment to deal damage creatively, often with added bonuses or area effects.
    - Will (Focus): Focus and stabilize your mental state to reduce incoming Nerve damage, temporarily decreasing the difficulty of subsequent checks.

Exploration:

- Navigate the military base between encounters.
- Discover pickups that restore Nerve or provide buffs, such as reducing the difficulty of certain checks or unlocking special dialogue-based abilities.
- Other soldiers can be found in the military base. They can be convinced to help through a Persuasion check (Difficulty: 8) by appealing to their sense of duty, or threatened into aiding you with an Intimidation check (Difficulty: 10). Successfully recruiting these soldiers allows the player to bypass combat encounters.

Objective:

- Clear all enemies in the area to "debug" the code and stabilize the base. The final encounter involves a "boss bug" with higher difficulty but significant rewards upon defeat.

Task 3: Solve a Series of Math Exercises (The quiz)

These tasks require the player to achieve at least 80% correct answers to pass. Passive checks in the background automatically provide the correct solutions based on the player's Knowledge attribute:

- Exercise 1: Convert an RGB value (e.g., 255, 0, 127) into a hexadecimal color code.
- Exercise 2: Calculate the resulting color when blending two hexadecimal codes (e.g., #FF0000 and #00FF00).
- Exercise 3: Determine the decimal equivalent of a given hexadecimal value (e.g., #1A).

Players manually attempt to solve each exercise. Passive checks may reveal hints or the entire solution if the player's Knowledge is high enough.

Outcomes

Success:

- Gain the "Web Wizard" skill, providing a bonus to all web-related tasks.
- Receive a special item: "Debugging Mug," which reduces the difficulty of future coding-related checks by 1.

Failure:

- Gain partial experience but lose credibility with the professor. This unlocks a side task to regain his trust through a supplementary project.

Advanced Event Photography Task Chain

Starting Point: Professor Chen from the Digital Media department needs photographers for an upcoming tech conference at THM. This task has an internal value for the quality of the pictures.

Task Trigger

- Prerequisites: Must have completed basic photography course
- Trigger: Notice board posting in the media lab or direct approach from Professor Chen

Task 1: Equipment Check (The Production) Professor Chen explains that the department's camera equipment needs testing and calibration before the event. The chosen parts influence the quality value as well as difficulty of the following photography check.

The first production step focuses on lens selection. Players can choose:

- Dirty Professional Zoom Lens: Quality -1 | Difficulty +1
    - Can be cleaned with cleaner
    - Clean Professional Zoom Lens: Quality +1 | Difficulty -1
- Standard Kit Lens: Quality: +0 | Difficulty +0
    - Found it the supply room in the same area
- Vintage Manual Lens: Quality: +2 | Difficulty +1
    - Can be bought at the vintage store
    - Another student has one but will only switch it for the clean professional zoom lens or the artistic bottle lens
- Artistic bottle lens: Quality: +3 | Difficulty +2
    - Requires a passed passive creativity check
    - Requires a bottle

Next comes camera settings when using the camera in the inventory:

- Auto Mode: Quality -1 | Difficulty -1
- Manual Mode: Quality +1 | Difficulty +1
- Custom Preset: Quality +2 | Difficulty +0
    - Requires successful knowledge check (Difficulty: 12) or the production skill

Finally, comes the camera stand::

- The influencer 3000: Quality +2 | Difficulty -1
    - Another student has it and will tell offer the amazon link
    - Can then be bought at a computer
- The ol' reliable: Quality +0 | Difficulty +0
    - Only one left is attached to a camera
    - Requires screwdriver to get
- A bunch of sticks: -1 | Difficulty +3
    - Can be found in most outside areas

Task 2: Location Scouting (The Mystery) The player receives a seemingly simple directive: "Find good spots for photos." However, success requires investigating:

Players gather spots by:

- Interviewing maintenance staff
- Reviewing architectural plans found in the basement
- Studying previous event photos on the flyers around

Each discovered location adds to a +1 quality, some areas planted as bad areas and give -1 quality.

Task 3: The Event Coverage (The Encounter) The actual conference presents three key photography challenges (perception encounter). The final perception check is the making the photo and is additionally influenced by the previous production of the camera. Success adds +2 quality for each photo:

Opening Ceremony: Players must navigate the crowd, find positioning and remove people from the shot.

Keynote Speaker: Players anticipate moments, capture reactions, and manage lighting.

Group photo : Players must coordinate the photo.

Outcomes

Complete Success (quality >= 10):

- If not unlocked through the course: "Production" skill unlocked
- Substantial financial reward
- Item: Stack of quality photos (+1 Creativity)
- Item: Camera (+2 perception) or Artistic Camera: (+3 Creativity, -1 Perception)
- Major affinity boost with the Synthesists

Partial Success (quality >= 5):

- Item: Stack of mediocre photos (+1 Creativity, -1 Perception)
- Item: Camera (+2 perception) or Artistic Camera: (+3 Creativity, -1 Perception)
- Minor affinity gain with the Synthesists

Failure (quality >= 4):

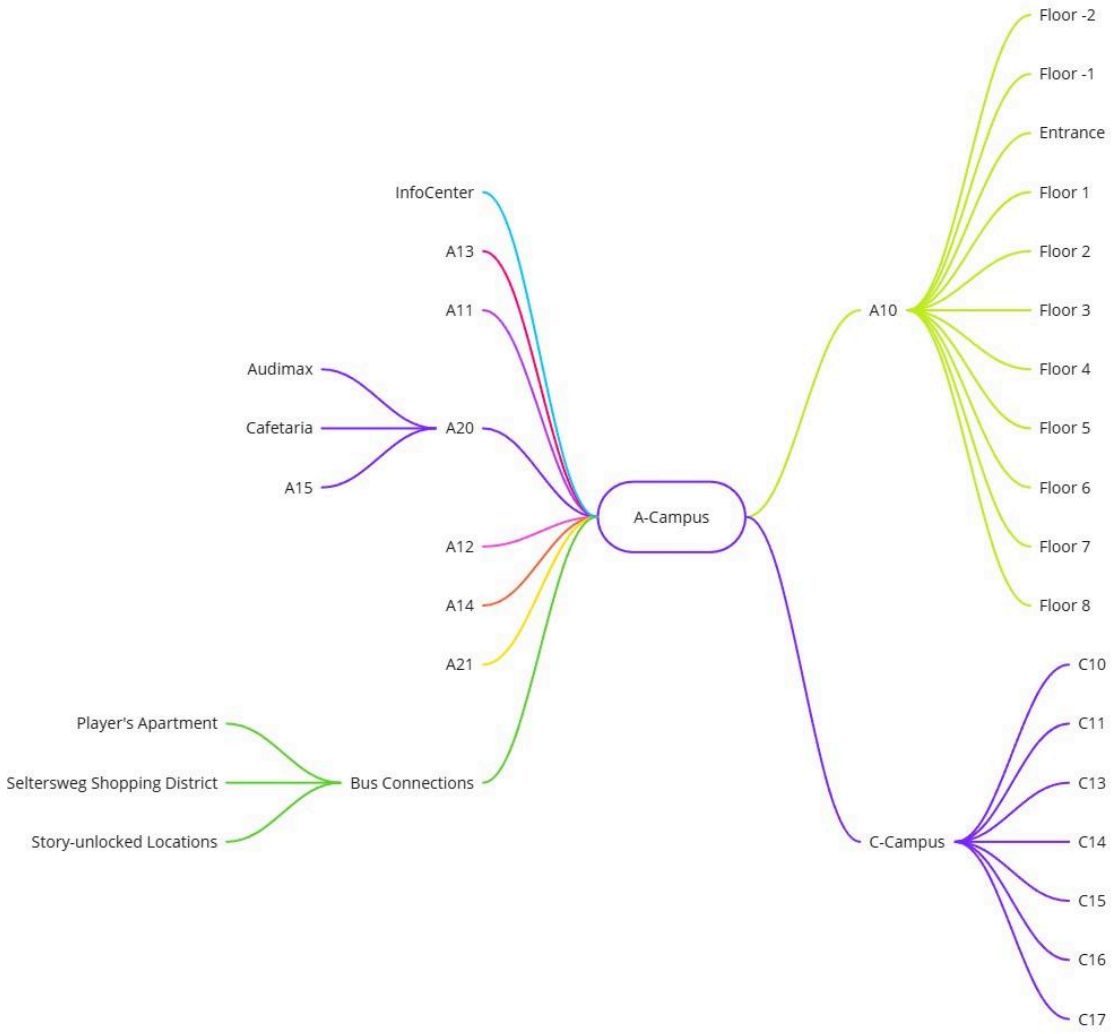
- Item: Stack of unusable photos (+1 Luck, -3 Perception)
- Affinity damage with the Synthesists

Special Personality Trait: Getting a quality of >=12 unlocks the "Master of Moments" personality trait, providing bonuses to future perception and creativity checks as well as lowering the difficulty of checks related to cameras by 5.

Game World

The game world is centered on THM's A-Campus along the Wiesenstraße in Gießen. While the campus serves as the primary game space, additional locations throughout Gießen become accessible as players discover them through tasks and conversations. These locations can be reached via the bus stops positioned near campus.

The game world consists of multiple interconnected areas with the A-Campus as the main center.



Core Buildings

Building A10

A10 functions as the primary academic building, spanning ten floors from the second basement to the eighth floor. The ground floor contains three major facilities: the main Mensa, a smaller Pastaria, and the AStA shop. These areas serve different gameplay purposes - the Mensa provides primary food items, the Pastaria offers specialty foods with unique effects, and the AStA shop stocks academic supplies needed for various tasks.

The building's elevator system enables vertical movement between floors, with access restrictions based on main task progress. Different departments occupy specific floors, housing lecture halls, computer labs, and specialized teaching spaces. The basement areas contain maintenance facilities and storage rooms that can be explored for items and task objectives.



Building A20

A20 houses the Audimax, which serves as the largest lecture hall space in the game. The building contains additional classrooms and a cafeteria that provides an alternative to the main Mensa with different food items.

Administrative Buildings

These buildings contain various administrative offices that become relevant during specific task chaines. These smaller structures house essential university services:

- A11: Examination office for course registration and grade processing
- A12: The IT Services area is relevant for multiple tasks as well as a shop for items that can help in IT related checks
- A22: InfoCenter providing a large range of information and tutorials for the player

The limited size and specific purposes of these buildings create natural task hubs for bureaucracy-related tasks.

Sports Center (A13)



The sports center provides facilities for physical activities and specialized gameplay elements. The building contains both indoor and outdoor sporting areas, equipment storage, and changing facilities. Access to the sports center opens additional task chains and provides alternative methods for character attribute development in the body category.

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Bus Transportation System

The bus system serves as the game's fast travel mechanic, connecting the A-Campus to various locations throughout Gießen. Each location contains at least one bus stop that opens a menu of available destinations. When a destination is selected, the player is transported there immediately through a fast travel system.

This system eliminates the need for continuous game space between locations while still providing access to important areas across Gießen. The first bus journey occurs after the tutorial sequence in the player's home, establishing the A-Campus as the initial travel point. From there, additional locations become available as they are discovered through tasks and conversations.

Connected Locations

Areas reached via bus are typically smaller, focused spaces serving specific purposes. These range from single-room locations used for specific tasks to slightly larger areas that may be revisited multiple times. Examples include:



- The player's apartment
- The city shopping district (Seltersweg)
- Various task-specific locations that unlock through story progression

The bus system's modular nature allows new locations to be easily added to the travel network as they become relevant to the player's journey, without requiring changes to the existing game world layout.





Inner Mind Spaces

The inner mind represents an alternate dimension within the game that visualizes academic concepts and mental processes. It consists of two distinct types of areas that serve different gameplay purposes.

Hub Area

A central mental space serves as the foundation of the inner mind. This hub acts as a place of self-reflection where players access their attribute allocation interface as well as access to their personality advisors.

The hub contains multiple locked passages leading to smaller areas, each representing different aspects of the character's personality and experiences. These rooms are unlocked through meaningful choices in the physical world throughout the game and repeated use of similar dialog options. Each unlocked room represents a personality trade and provides a combination of:

- Permanent bonuses to specific attributes
- Unique dialogue options
- Gameplay-defining trade-offs that fundamentally alter how certain game systems work for that character

These trade-offs can significantly impact gameplay mechanics, such as altering food item interactions, adding special conditions to certain actions, or providing alternative rewards for specific behaviors. This makes each unlocked room a meaningful choice that shapes not just the character's capabilities, but how they interact with the game's core systems.

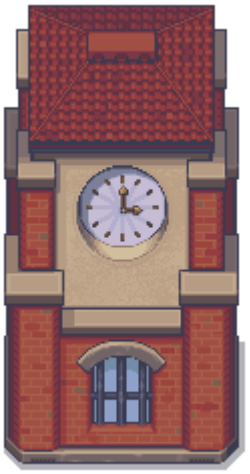
Course Visualization Areas

During specific courses, players enter specialized inner mind spaces that transform academic concepts into interactive environments. These areas follow a linear structure, presenting players with a clear path forward through the course material. Each space is uniquely designed around its academic content, using environmental storytelling and light puzzle elements to convey course information in an engaging way.

Unlike the physical world, the inner mind does not allow item collection or storage. Instead, these spaces focus purely on the visualization and understanding of concepts. Players must solve challenges using their accumulated knowledge and attributes rather than collected items or equipment.

The inner mind's surreal nature allows it to ignore conventional rules of space and physics, enabling creative representations of abstract concepts while maintaining gameplay clarity. This system provides an alternative method of presenting course content without relying on traditional academic formats.

Time System



The game uses a dynamic day-night cycle based on in-game time, but with an important distinction from real-time systems: time only advances through player actions, so the player never feels rushed or stressed by time pressure. Different actions advance time by varying amounts:

- Basic interactions like picking up items or selecting dialogue options advance time by 1 minute
- Moving between areas costs 5 minutes
- Using the bus system takes between 10-60 minutes depending on destination distance
- Performing attribute checks requires 2 minutes

Day Phases

The day is divided into four distinct phases: morning, noon, evening, and night. Each phase brings changes to both NPC location and area accessibility. NPCs follow schedules, moving between locations based on the time of day - professors might only be in their offices during certain hours, while the cafeteria staff changes shifts throughout the day.

The time system affects task availability throughout the day. Administrative offices operate during business hours, while some tasks require specific time periods like nighttime for completion.

Sleep Mechanics

Sleep serves as the primary method for restoring nerve points in THMastery. Players can only sleep during nighttime hours, and doing so advances time to the next day while fully restoring their nerve points. Sleep also removes the effects of the active food item in addition to all temporary effects.

Narrative & Story

Story Outline

Overview

The main narrative of THMastery follows a new student at THM as they uncover and become entangled in "Project Paradigm," a secret research initiative that has begun to affect the very fabric of reality. The story unfolds through a main task chain called "Reality's Edge," which integrates closely with the player's academic progression.

Project Paradigm

Project Paradigm represents THM's most ambitious research initiative, combining cutting-edge technology with unexpected consequences. The project began as separate research initiatives across three departments. The Computer Science department developed a quantum computing array exhibiting unexplained phenomena. The Digital Media department created a neural interface network for studying human-computer interaction. The Mathematics department contributed a consciousness mapping algorithm for educational optimization. When these systems unexpectedly synchronized, they began allowing human consciousness to influence reality itself.

The key components of Project Paradigm are:

- The Quantum Array: A sophisticated computing system beneath the library
- Neural Interface Network: A campus-wide consciousness-sensing system
- Consciousness Mapping Algorithm: Software that translates human thought into reality-altering commands

Story Progression

Act 1: The New Student

The story begins with the player arriving at THM as a new Digital Media student. Their first semester introduces the university's surface normalcy while hinting at deeper mysteries. Strange occurrences manifest with increasing frequency - computer screens displaying impossible colors, physics behaving oddly in certain areas, and students sharing synchronized dreams. These incidents escalate from subtle glitches to undeniable reality distortions, culminating in a major system malfunction that forces Project Paradigm into the open.

Act 2: The Project

The discovery of Project Paradigm reveals a deep divide among THM's faculty. Three distinct approaches emerge to handle the growing reality distortions:

The Stabilizers, led by Professor Weber from Computer Science, operate from a secure server facility. Their conservative approach focuses on containing and reversing the reality breaches, fearing the consequences of uncontrolled reality manipulation.

The Synthesists under Professor Chen work from the Digital Media lab's experimental VR facility. They view the phenomenon as an opportunity, seeking to harness and control reality manipulation for advancement of human-computer interaction.

The Accelerationists, guided by Professor Kraus, conduct radical experiments from their underground Mathematics research space. They believe reality itself is computational and actively work to push through the current crisis toward a new stage of existence.

Act 3: The Crisis

As Project Paradigm's influence grows beyond anyone's control, reality itself begins to fragment across campus. As reality fragments across campus, each faction launches their own desperate attempt to resolve the crisis. The Stabilizers begin constructing a massive containment field around the quantum array, requiring the player to help stabilize key nodes across campus while reality actively works against them. Meanwhile, the Synthesists attempt to create a controlled manifestation zone in the digital media labs, believing they can channel the chaos into manageable forms. The Accelerationists seize this moment to attempt a massive consciousness transfer experiment, trying to push through what they see as reality's chrysalis stage.

As the crisis deepens, each faction's attempts to implement their solutions only make the situation more unstable. The university administration abandons attempts at normalcy, instead establishing "safe zones" while trying to prevent knowledge of the situation from spreading beyond campus.The situation reaches critical mass when the quantum array attempts to expand beyond campus boundaries. The factions unite briefly to contain this expansion, but their cooperation quickly breaks down into a three-way power struggle for control of Project Paradigm's core systems. The player must choose which faction to support - or whether to pursue their own solution - while reality itself hangs in the balance.

Climax and Choice

Project Paradigm reaches critical instability, forcing a final choice that will affect both THM and potentially reality itself. The player must choose between four distinct paths:

Stabilization represents the conservative option, working with Weber to shut down Project Paradigm and restore normal reality. This preserves traditional education but loses all potential benefits of the research.

Synthesis follows Chen's middle path, establishing controlled reality manipulation. This transforms education and research through reality-bending while attempting to maintain safety protocols, though long-term consequences remain unknown.

Transcendence embraces Kraus's radical vision, pushing through the reality barrier to fundamentally alter existence. This path risks completely dissolving normal reality in pursuit of humanity's evolution.

Control, the hidden path, requires masterful navigation of all three factions while maintaining independence. This most challenging ending grants the player personal control over Project Paradigm's reality-altering capabilities.

The Factions

The Stabilizers - Department of Computer Science

The Stabilizers emerged from the Computer Science department's original Project Paradigm research team. Led by Professor Weber, they operate from a converted server facility deep within the department's restricted area. This space, filled with monitoring equipment and experimental containment systems, reflects their methodical approach to the crisis.

Professor Weber, the faction's leader, helped design Project Paradigm's quantum array. His intimate knowledge of the system's potential drives his cautious approach. Working alongside him is Dr. Müller, a quantum computing specialist whose initial excitement about the project turned to dread after witnessing early containment failures. Their primary research team consists of systems engineers and computer scientists who view reality as a stable system that should not be tampered with.

The Stabilizers approach the crisis with scientific rigor and conservative methodology. Their key research priorities include:

- Developing containment protocols for reality breaches
- Understanding the fundamental mechanics of reality distortion
- Creating "patch" programs to stabilize affected areas
- Documenting and classifying anomaly types

Within their secure facility, they maintain the most comprehensive database of reality distortion events and their effects. Their work focuses on understanding these phenomena not to exploit them, but to reverse them. They view the breakdown of reality as an existential threat to both the university and potentially existence itself.

The Synthesists - Department of Digital Media

Operating from the Digital Media department's cutting-edge VR lab, the Synthesists represent a middle path between containment and acceleration. Professor Chen transformed this space into a testing ground for controlled reality manipulation, combining traditional research equipment with areas designed to safely experiment with reality-bending effects.

Professor Chen's background in human-computer interaction shapes the faction's approach. Their second-in-command, Dr. Santos, brings expertise in cognitive science and interface design. Together, they lead a diverse team of researchers combining technical expertise with creative vision.

The Synthesists base their work on four core principles:

- Reality manipulation should serve human advancement
- Controlled experimentation can lead to safe implementation

- Technology and consciousness are naturally converging
- Education must evolve with these new possibilities

Their research focuses heavily on practical applications. They design interfaces that allow controlled reality manipulation, develop safety protocols for "enhanced" spaces, and document potential educational applications. The Synthesists believe humanity's relationship with reality is naturally evolving, and their role is to guide this evolution responsibly.

The Accelerationists - Department of Mathematics

The Accelerationists conduct their radical experiments from a converted underground lecture hall, now filled with complex equations and experimental apparatus. Professor Kraus transformed this space into what they call the "Computation Chamber," where the boundaries between mathematics and reality blur most freely.

Professor Kraus, once a traditional theoretical physicist, experienced a profound shift in perspective after early Project Paradigm experiments suggested reality's computational nature. Dr. Fischer, their lead researcher, contributes crucial quantum mechanics expertise. Their team consists mainly of theoretical mathematicians and physicists who view current reality as merely one possible configuration of a deeper computational substrate.

The Accelerationists have developed several radical theories:

- Reality is fundamentally computational and can be reprogrammed
- Human consciousness represents an emergent computational process
- Project Paradigm's effects indicate an impending phase transition in reality
- Traditional physics represents an outdated framework

Their work extends far beyond traditional research. They actively seek to expand reality breaches, conduct dangerous consciousness transfer experiments, and push the boundaries of what's possible. The Accelerationists believe the current crisis isn't a problem to be solved but rather humanity's first step toward a transcendent new mode of existence.

Faction Dynamics

The three factions maintain an uneasy coexistence, competing for resources and influence while trying to prevent open conflict. The university administration attempts to balance their competing interests while maintaining plausible deniability about the full scope of their activities. Each faction actively recruits promising students, seeking to strengthen their position in the ongoing ideological and practical struggle over Project Paradigm's future.

Course and Story Integration

The main task chain and course progression are designed to complement and reinforce each other. Story progression directly enables academic advancement, while course skills become necessary to handle escalating challenges.

- Main task chain awards potential points at key story beats
- Each story phase requires skills from specific courses to progress

- Inner mind sequences in courses become increasingly strange as reality destabilizes
- Special courses unlock in later phases, featuring reality-warped content

World Impact

As Project Paradigm's influence grows, both the campus environment and its inhabitants undergo significant changes. These changes affect everything from locations to behaviors of NPCs.

- Campus locations develop permanent anomalies
- Task objectives become increasingly surreal
- NPCs react differently based on reality's stability
- New surreal NPCs join the campus

User Interface

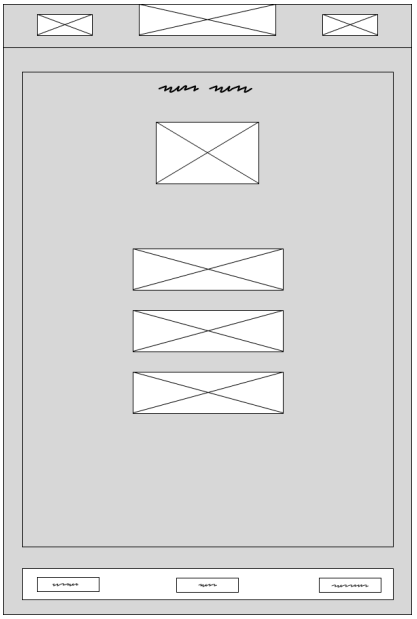
Information Channels

Information	**Priority**	**Information Channel**
Direct Environment	Always visible	Entire Screen
Nerve	Always visible	Left corner
Temporary effects	Always visible	Left corner
Currently consumed food	Always visible	Left corner
Menu Options (Buttons)	Always visible	Left corner
Inventory	Sometimes visible	Right side
Task Menu	Sometimes visible	Right side
Character Attributes	Sometimes visible	Right side
Skill Menu	Sometimes visible	Right side
Interaction options	Sometimes visible	Around cursor
Dialog Menu	Sometimes visible	Right side
Main Menu	Sometimes visible	Center

Wireframes

The game's menu system is designed with a modern, smartphone-inspired interface. Drawing from familiar mobile design patterns, each game feature is presented as a distinct "app" within this system. Players can navigate between different views using a bottom navigation bar, similar to how they would switch between apps on a phone. This approach makes the inventory and other game information easily accessible while maintaining an intuitive, contemporary feel.

Game Menu



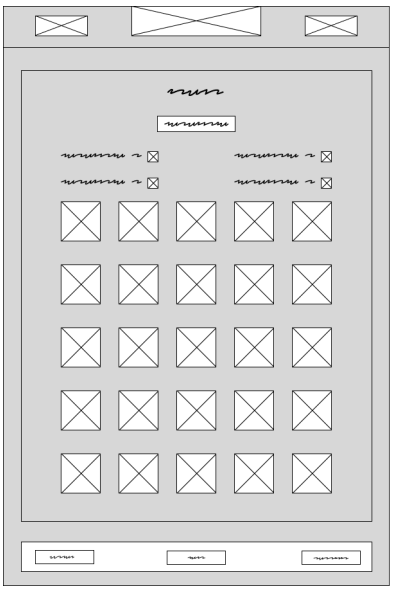
The Game Menu wireframe illustrates the core layout of the game menu.

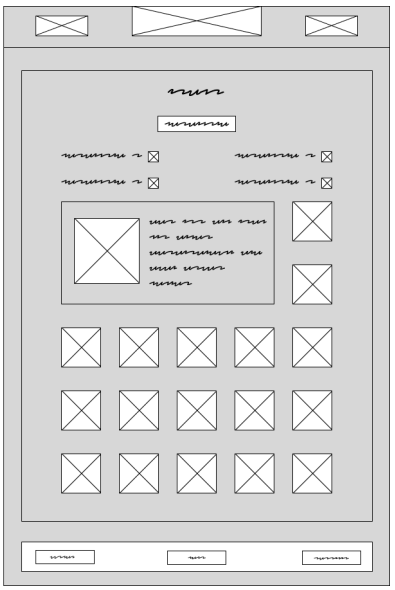
The design follows a vertical layout with primary interaction elements arranged in a column. Navigation elements are positioned in a horizontal bar at the bottom of the screen, while additional images are displayed in a horizontal bar at the top.

Inventory

The Inventory wireframe demonstrates the layout for managing the player's collected items.

The interface features category filters at the top of the screen, with checkboxes for different item types and an "All Items" option. The main content area displays items in a 5x5 grid layout. When an item is selected, the view transitions to show a detailed panel with the item's thumbnail and extended information while maintaining visibility of the remaining inventory grid.

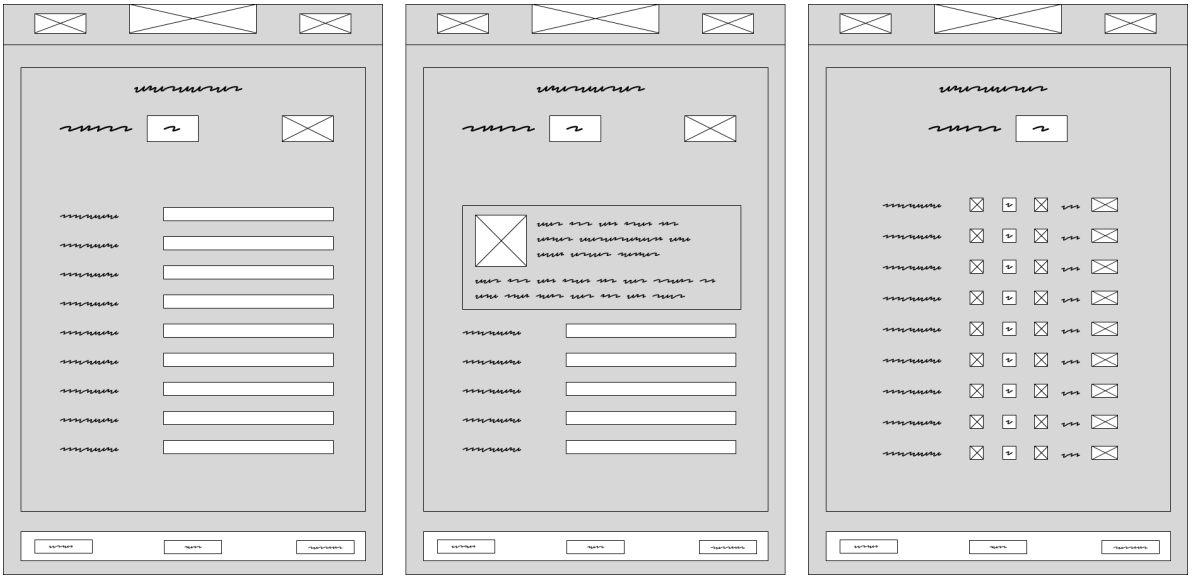




Attributes

The Attributes wireframe illustrates the interface for viewing and modifying character attributes.

The main view displays character attributes in a vertical list, each with a progress bar showing its current value. At the top of the screen, the number of available attribute points is shown along with an "Assign Points" button. When assigning points, the interface transitions to show individual attribute adjustment controls with clear maximum value indicators. Each attribute can be modified using increment/decrement controls, with the remaining points displayed for reference.

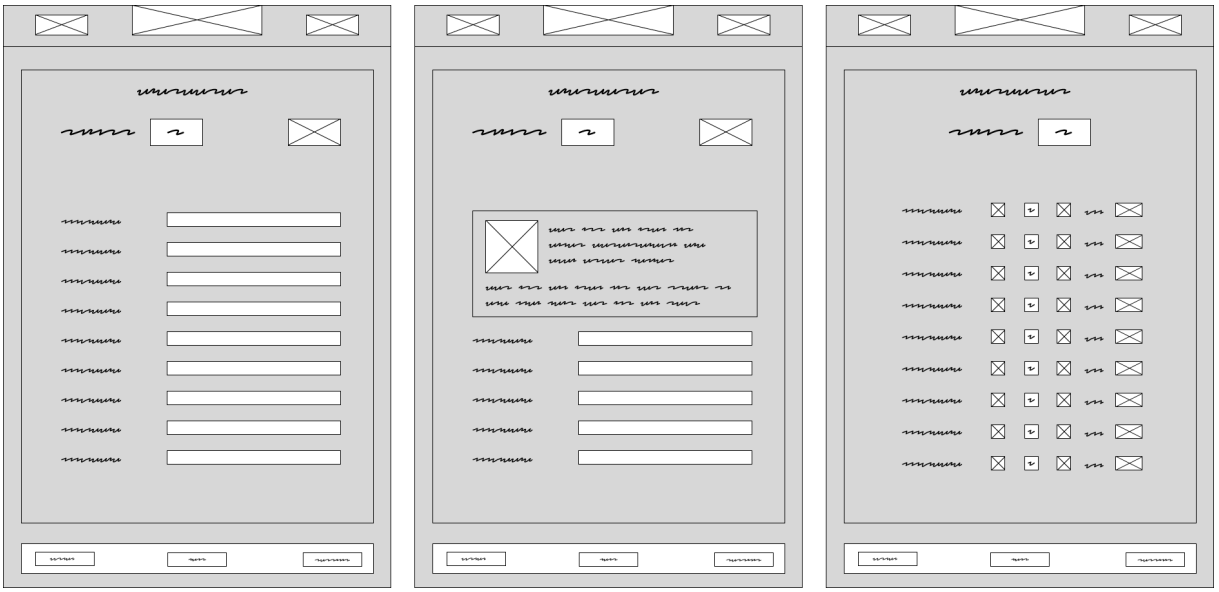


Tasks

The Tasks wireframe outlines the interface for managing player objectives and assignments.

The main view presents tasks in a categorized list format, separating them into main and secondary categories. Each task entry appears as a selectable item in a scrollable list. When a task is selected, the interface transitions to a detailed view showing the task's description, objectives, and current progress.

The interface consists of three states: the category selection at the top, the task list in the main view, and the detailed task view upon selection, with the standard navigation elements remaining at the bottom of the screen.

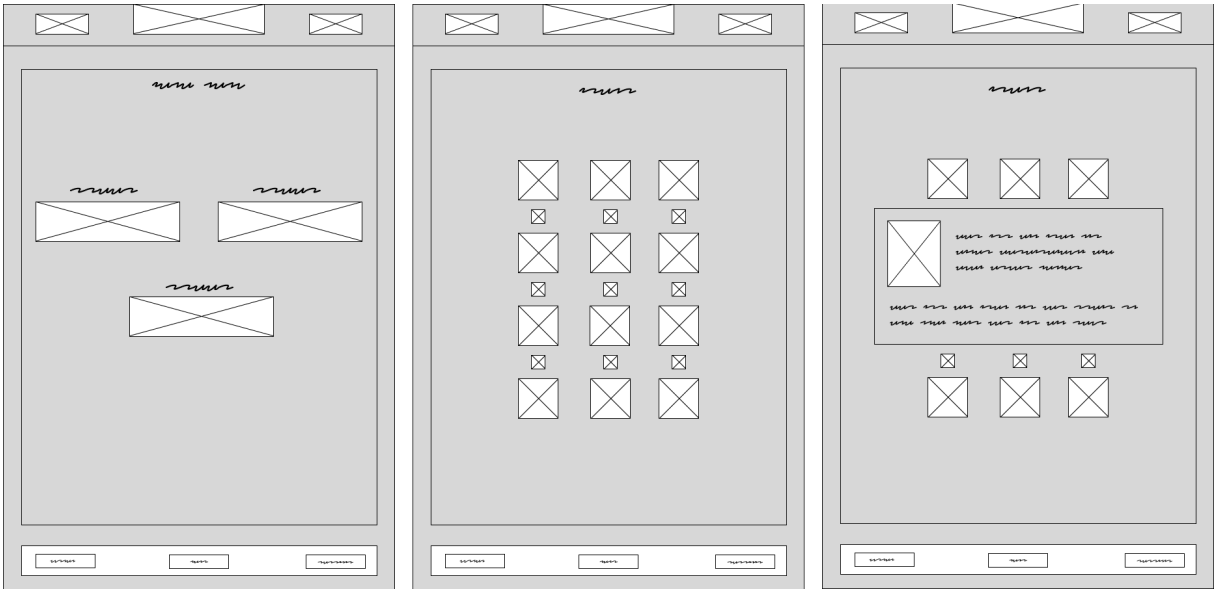


Skill Tree

The Skill Tree wireframe displays the interface for viewing and selecting character abilities.

The interface shows three distinct states: a category selection screen with major skill groupings, a grid layout of skill icons organized by their relationships, and a detailed view that appears when selecting a specific skill. The skill icons are connected by lines to show prerequisites and progression paths, while smaller connecting nodes indicate the requirements for unlocking new abilities.

The interface preserves the standard navigation at the bottom while using the majority of the screen space to clearly display the skill relationships and descriptions.

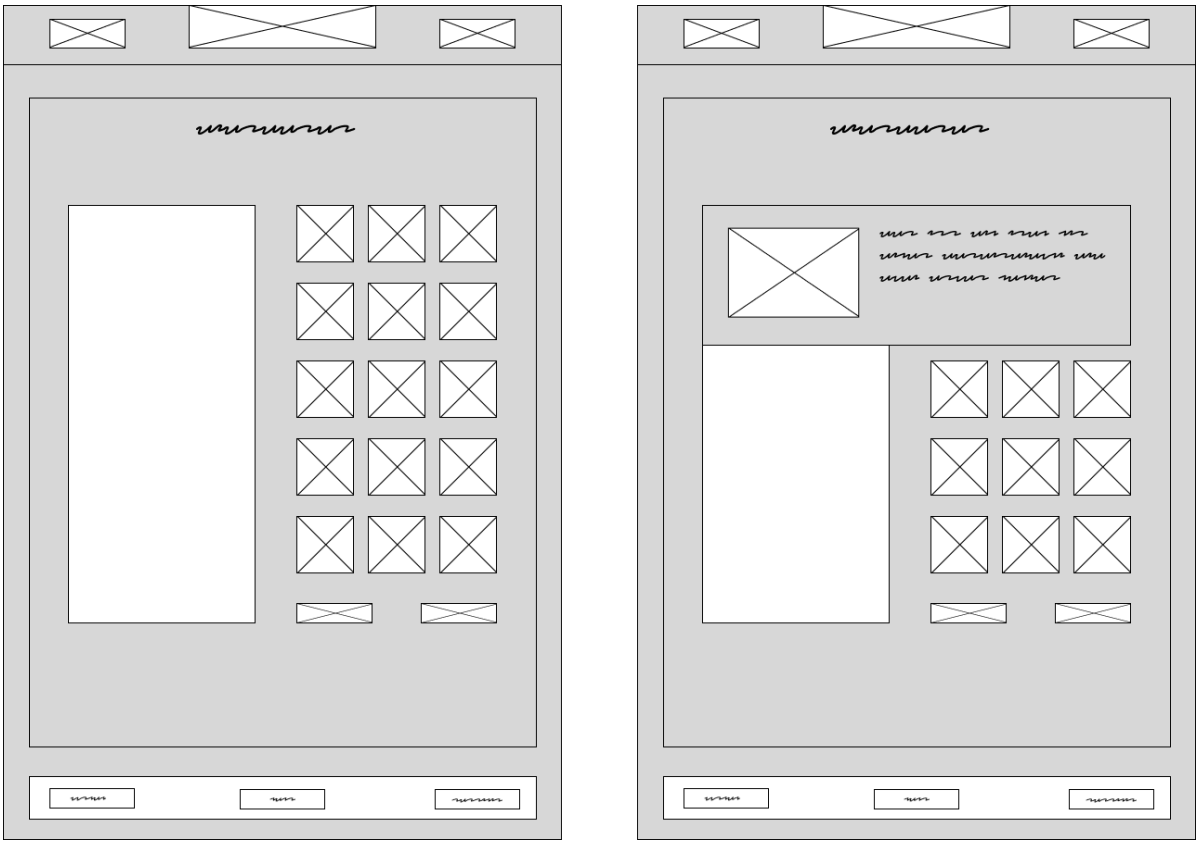


Character Sheet

The Character Sheet wireframe shows the interface for customizing the player character's appearance through equipment.

The interface is split into two main sections: a large character preview window on the left, and an equipment selection grid on the right. When an item is selected, the character preview immediately updates to show how the item will look when equipped. Navigation buttons below the equipment grid allow players to cycle through different categories of items.

The layout shows two states: the basic view with character preview and item selection, and a detailed view that displays additional information about the selected item while maintaining the preview window.



Input and Controls

THMastery is built on the principle of accessibility, with a primary focus on mouse-only gameplay. While keyboard shortcuts are available, they serve as optional enhancements rather than essential controls.

Mouse Controls

Primary Mouse Button (Left Click):

- **Movement**: Players navigate through the game world by clicking their desired destination
- **Inventory Management**: Items can be picked up, moved, and organized within the inventory system
- **Basic Interactions**: Initiating conversations, picking up items, and activating objects in the world

Secondary Mouse Button (Right Click):

- **Item Inspection**: Examining objects in the game world reveals detailed descriptions and potential uses
- **Inventory Usage**: Activating items directly from the inventory without needing to drag them

Mouse Hover:

- Shows tooltips for items and interactive elements
- Reveals additional information about NPCs
- Displays skill check probabilities in conversations

Keyboard Shortcuts

While not essential for gameplay, keyboard shortcuts provide efficient alternatives for frequent actions:

Input Map:

- **T**: Opens Task Menu
- **I**: Toggles Inventory
- **C**: Accesses Attribute Menu
- **K**: Opens Skill Menu
- **Esc**: Brings up Game Menu
- **Spacebar**: Selects default dialog option

Action-Context Menu

The Action-Context Menu provides contextual interactions when players hold the left mouse button on interactive objects in the game world.

The menu appears as a radial interface around the cursor, displaying only relevant interaction options for the selected object. For example, the inspection option will not appear if the object has no inspection text, ensuring that only meaningful interactions are presented. The default interaction is always shown on the cursor itself, while additional options appear in the radial menu.



Available interactions include:

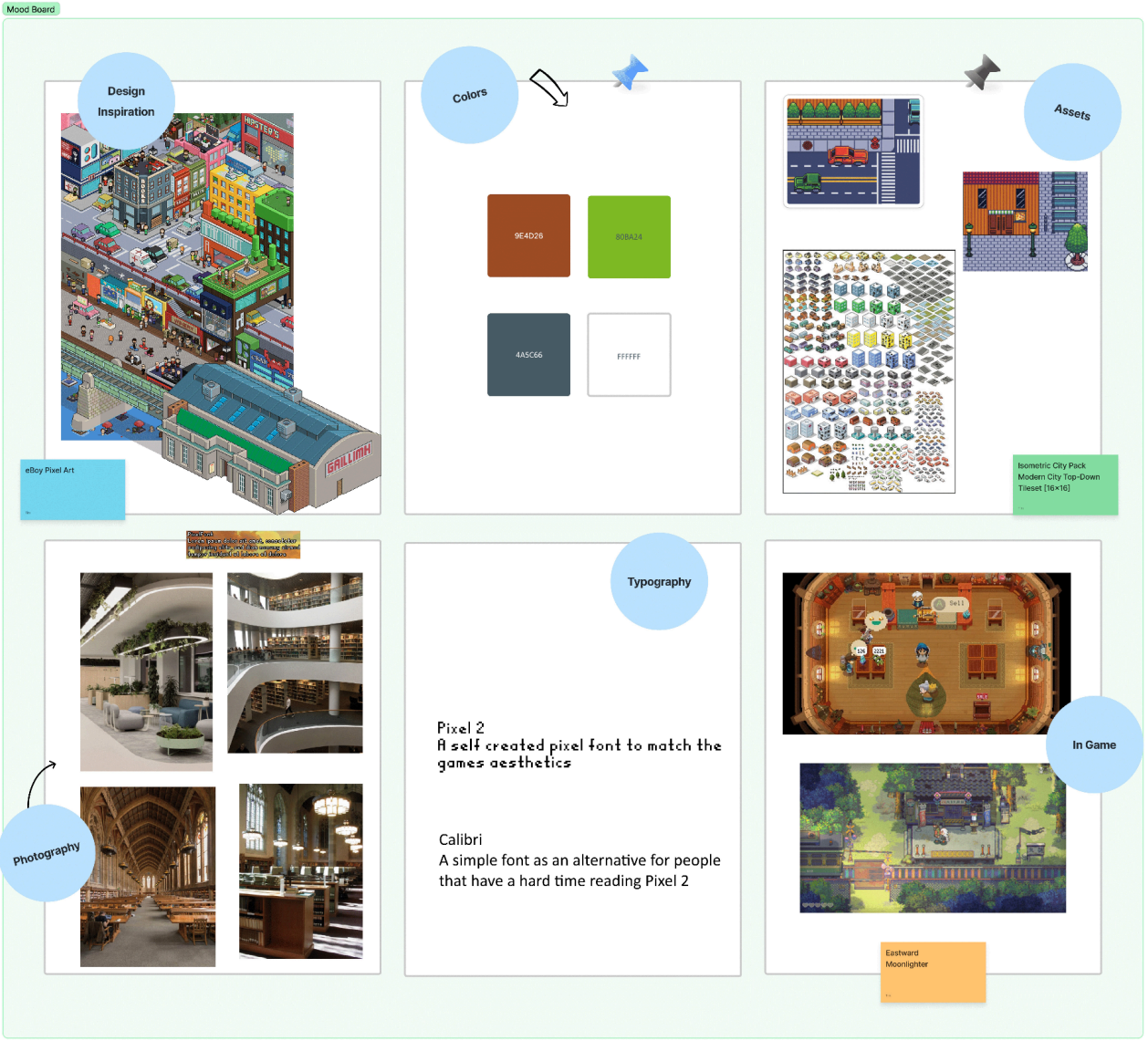
- Picking up items (default interaction for collectibles)
- Inspecting objects (default interaction for signs)
- Initiating a conversation (default interaction for NPCs)
- Reading text from readable items
- Using inventory items on objects
- Performing contextual skill checks (e.g., lock picking)
- Object-specific actions unique to certain interactables (e.g., moving to a different area)

The interface dynamically adjusts its available options based on the selected object and current context. Each interactive object may have unique combinations of these options based on its properties.

Audio-Visual and Software Design

Art style

The visual design of THMastery combines pixel art aesthetics with the THM's established visual identity to create a cohesive and recognizable game world.



Core Visual Style

The exterior environments utilize a vibrant pixel art style inspired by modern city landscapes, featuring detailed building facades and street-level elements. This approach allows for clear readability while maintaining visual charm. The color palette emphasizes warm browns (#4E4524) and vibrant greens (#76BA2D) contrasted against neutral grays (#4A5C66) and whites (#FFFFFF), reflecting THM's official branding while adding environmental variety.

Interior Design

Interior spaces draw direct inspiration from THM's existing architecture with a slight modern touch as documented in the reference photography. Key architectural elements like modern study spaces and traditional classrooms are translated into the game's visual style while maintaining their recognizable characteristics. These areas use a more subdued color palette that matches the real-world locations.





Typography

Two font options support different player needs:

- Pixel 2: A custom-designed pixel font that matches the game's primary aesthetic, used as the default typeface
- Calibri: An alternative sans-serif font option for improved readability, available through the accessibility settings

Assets

THMastery's visual assets are primarily sourced from LimeZu's Modern collection, chosen for its comprehensive tileset system and flexible character framework. The collection's modular design allows for rapid prototyping and efficient asset modification when needed. Most importantly the assets feature full adaptive character.

Character System Features:

- Complete character customization support
- Multiple clothing layers for equipment visualization
- Consistent animation sets across all character variants
- Standardized sprite sizes for seamless integration

The Modern collection provides a unified visual framework that extends beyond characters to include furniture, buildings, and environmental details. This consistency eliminates potential art style clashes while maintaining the flexibility. All game assets follow the collection's established pixel density and color palette conventions, ensuring visual cohesion throughout the game world.

When custom assets are required, they are created following the Modern collection's established style guide to maintain visual consistency.

Asset Name	Description	Link	Artist	Price
Modern Interiors	• Thousands of furniture variants and styles • 2D and 3D walls • 100+ frame-by-frame animated objects • Modular tiles (walls, floors, carpets, tables) • Character customization system: - 100+ outfits - 200 hairstyles - 80 accessories - 9 skin colors • Comprehensive animation sets • UI elements • Visible upstairs transitions • Individual furniture sprite files	Modern Interiors	LimeZu	$2.49
Modern Exteriors	• Complete street and building tilesets • 8-directional animated vehicles • Frame-by-frame animations (.gif and sheets) • Multiple size options (16x16, 32x32, 48x48)	Modern Exteriors	LimeZu	$1.50
Modern Office	• Extensive furniture variations • Multiple shadow options • Multiple sprite sizes (16x, 32x, 48x) • 300+ individual sprites • Modern Interiors compatibility	Modern Office	LimeZu	$2.49
Serene Village	• Environmental assets (terrain, trees, rocks) • 24 house variations • Animated object collection	Serene Village	LimeZu	$0.00
Smart Phone Assets	• 3 Smartphone UI Templates	Phone Template	Hadara Madrak	$0.00

Asset Name	Description	Link	Artist	Price
Pixel Art GUI Elements	• Complete GUI Texture Atlas	GUI Elements	Mounir Tohami	$0.00
Game Icon	• 2 Custom Game Icons	Private Commission	Adrian Sonneborn	$0.00
Animated Mini Characters	• A bunch of friendly characters for your game	Animated Mini Characters	LimeZu	$0.00

Audio

The audiovisual design of THMastery will reinforce environmental immersion and provide clear feedback to player actions. The sound design will be based on realistic ambient audio and interactive cues, while the music system is designed to enhance different locations and activities within the game without overwhelming the experience.

Sound

The sound design focuses on establishing a believable university atmosphere through layered audio elements. The core of this system is environmental audio, with dynamic environmental sounds that adjust based on area. Indoor areas populated with NPCs feature sounds of a crowded room, whereas outdoor areas can go from traffic to serene bird sounds based on the intended feeling of the area.

Environmental feedback is handled through a context-aware footstep system. Indoor footsteps feature subtle echoes and surface reflections, while outdoor steps will vary based on ground material. This system will expand to include variations for different floor types like tile, carpet, and concrete.

The planned sound implementation will be:

- Interactive object sounds for doors, computers, and vending machines
- Location-specific ambient sound layers for different building types
- Weather effects for outdoor areas
- UI feedback for menus and interactions
- NPC reaction sounds during conversations

Music

The music in *THMastery* focuses on being non-intrusive and maintaining atmosphere rather than guiding player emotions. The music system will use location-based triggers and dialog flags to manage track playback. Each area in the game then has a designated default track, while special events or story moments can override the location-based music with higher-priority tracks.

The system will handle track switching through a priority system with crossfading transitions. When players move between areas, the system checks for music triggers and smoothly transitions between tracks over a short duration. All tracks are designed for seamless looping to maintain a consistent atmosphere during extended play.

Track assignments and usage are defined as follows:

Track Name	**Function**	**Usage**
Let's Go	General exploration theme	Played in hallways and general campus movement
Party Tonight	Social event music	Used in parties or student gatherings
Soothing Backyard	Relaxed background track	Used in outdoor spaces and quieter areas
The Café	Casual indoor ambiance	Played in the university café and lounge areas
Slow Ride	Low-intensity exploration	Used for transitional spaces and casual movement
Traffic Lights	Urban background sound	Used in outdoor city-adjacent locations
Panorama	Reflective/atmospheric track	Used for moments of narrative importance

Software Components

THMastery is built using Godot Engine 3.5, an open-source game development platform that provides the core infrastructure for the game. The engine's node-based architecture and built-in scripting language (GDScript) handle the fundamental systems including character movement, scene management, and UI implementation.

For the game's extensive dialogue system, we utilize Dialogic 2.0, a community-developed plugin for Godot that manages branching conversations and character interactions. This plugin provides the framework for our complex dialogue trees, character portraits, and choice-based narrative progression. Dialogic's timeline system also helps manage our skill check integration within conversations.

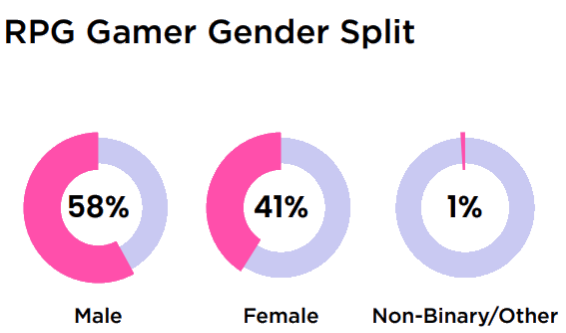
Additionally, Godot's built-in resource system manages our asset pipeline, handling everything from character sprites to UI elements, while its animation system powers both character movements and UI transitions. The engine's scene system allows us to efficiently organize and load different areas of the university campus.

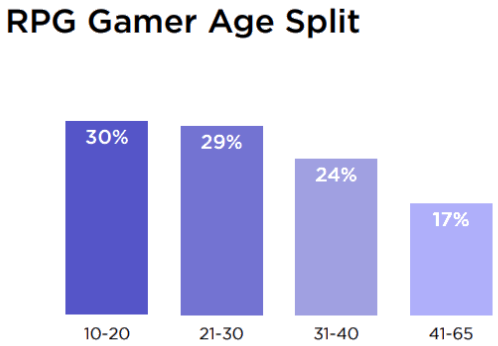
Analysis

Target Group Analysis

Once considered niche entertainment, gaming has established itself as a significant medium in Germany, capturing more than half of the population as active participants (Bitkom 2023a).

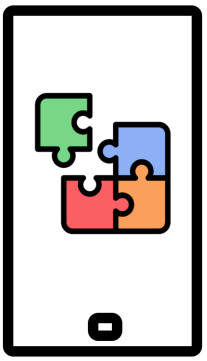
Examining the **demographic** landscape reveals several compelling characteristics. Recent years have seen the gender divide virtually disappear, with player distribution reaching notable balance (Bitkom 2023b). When looking specifically at RPG players, the gender distribution shows a moderate male majority of gamers (Newzoo 2022a). Among age groups, the 16-30 year segment emerges as the most actively engaged, demonstrating particularly intensive participation patterns for games (Bitkom 2023c) and RPGs in particular. In terms of educational background, the gaming community includes players particularly with higher education or entrance qualification (game 2021).





The German gaming market shows clear **platform and genre** preferences, with smartphones and laptops emerging as the primary gaming devices (Bitkom 2023e). On PC and console platforms, action role-playing games dominate, with first/third-person shooters and sports/racing games following as strong contenders (Statista 2022a). RPGs maintain a particularly strong position in the PC gaming market, ranking as the third most popular genre by active users (Newzoo 2022), and show significant overlap with adventure game audiences (Newzoo 2022). The mobile gaming landscape features different preferences, with puzzle and quiz games reigning supreme, followed by card games and educational titles (Statista 2022b).





Consumer behavior in the German market points to robust potential. Digital distribution has become the overwhelming choice for PC gaming (game 2024), complemented by a strong majority of players who consistently invest in new gaming experiences (Bitkom 2023f). Looking ahead, **market forecasts** signal continued growth in the German gaming market (PwC 2024), with digital distribution establishing itself as the primary sales channel (game 2024). Particularly since Role-Playing Games (RPGs) are estimated to be the highest-revenue genre across all platforms (Newzoo 2022).

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Personas

The Focused Student

A busy master's student seeking intellectual engagement through gaming, Marie represents casual players who value depth but need flexibility. She looks for games that can be enjoyed in shorter sessions while still offering meaningful challenges.

The Focused Student: Marie Weber



"Between lectures, I need something that challenges my mind without overwhelming me."

Age: 23
Job: Student
Family: Single
Place of Living: Gießen
Typ: Explorer

Goals

- Seeks intellectual challenges in games
- Wants to achieve progress in short gaming sessions
- Looks for games with depth that remain accessible
- Values learning elements through gameplay

Frustrations

- Games with too steep learning curves
- Lack of save options for short sessions
- Shallow mobile games without depth
- Overly long tutorial phases

Bio / Story

Marie is a dedicated master's student who enjoys mentally stimulating games between lectures and library visits. She discovered gaming during her bachelor's degree while looking for an alternative to endless social media scrolling. With her structured time management, she consciously plans gaming breaks but prefers games she can pause at any time.

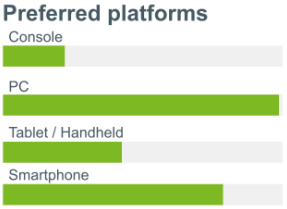
Motivations



Games / Genres

- Puzzle Games
- Adventure Games
- Educational Games

Preferred platforms



The Story Seeker

Representing players who prioritize narrative depth, Lukas approaches games as interactive literature. His focus on story and character development reflects a segment of players who value rich storytelling and meaningful narrative choices.

The Story Seeker: Lukas Becker



"I love games that make me think and tell compelling stories. Graphics aren't everything - give me good writing and interesting choices."

Age: 32
Job: PhD Student
Family: In a relationship, living with boyfriend
Place of Living: Wetzlar
Typ: Achiever (Enjoys completing stories + finding all narrative paths)

Goals

- Wants to experience engaging narratives
- Seeks meaningful choices in games
- Enjoys discovering all possible story outcomes
- Looking for games with literary or cultural depth

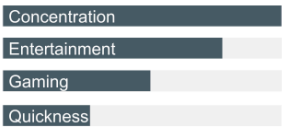
Frustrations

- Shallow or poorly written dialogues
- Limited story branching options
- Interruptions during story moments
- Games prioritizing action over narrative

Bio / Story

Lukas divides his time between his doctoral research and his passion for interactive storytelling. Living with his boyfriend in Wetzlar while pursuing his PhD, he appreciates how games can tell stories in ways other media cannot. He typically plays in the evening after his research work, while his partner grades papers (who's a high school teacher), often taking notes about narrative structures and choice architectures that might be relevant to his studies in interactive narratives.

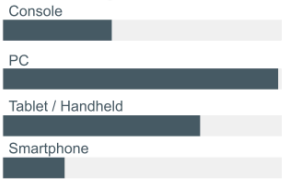
Motivations



Games / Genres

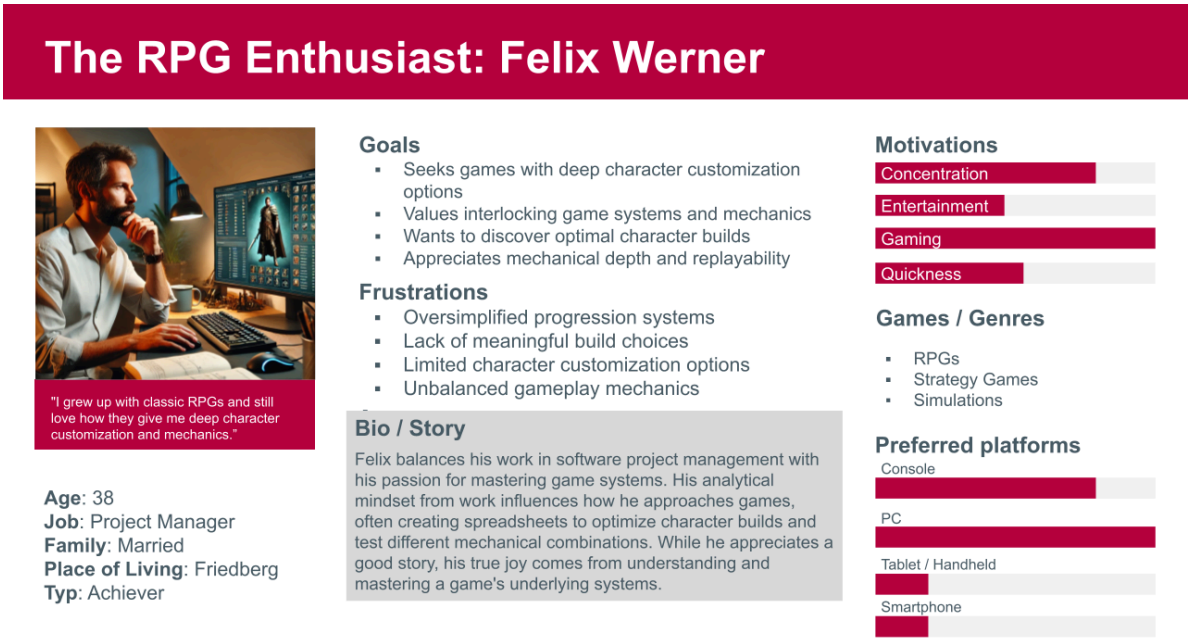
- Adventure Games
- Visual Novels
- RPGs

Preferred platforms



The Systems Master

An experienced RPG player who approaches games with an analytical mindset, Felix represents players who love to master complex game mechanics. He embodies the technically-minded segment that values deep customization and mechanical depth.



User Story Mapping

The following User Story Mapping outlines the core features and player interactions of our narrative-driven university RPG. Based on our three player personas - the Focused Student (Marie), the Story Seeker (Lukas), and the Systems Master (Felix) - these stories reflect different player needs and preferences. The user stories are organized into seven key epics:

UI and Settings: Basic game interface and configuration options that control how players interact with the game.

Tutorial: Systems that teach players how the game works.

Character Development: Options and mechanics for creating and advancing the player's character.

World: The game environment, its locations, and how players interact with them.

Dialog: Conversation systems and character interactions.

Objectives: Tasks and activities players need to complete.

Story: Main narrative and how player choices affect it.

UI and Settings	As a focused student, I want to be able to save anywhere so that I can quickly exit between classes	As a story seeker, I want clear text formatting and readability options so that I can fully immerse in the narrative	As a systems master, I want detailed UI information about game data so that I can make informed decisions	As a focused student, I want to have a clear and easy-to-use interface to understand all interactions in the game quickly.
Tutorial	As a focused student, I want intuitive tutorial integration so that I can learn while playing	As a systems master, I want detailed mechanics explanations so that I can understand all gameplay possibilities	As a story seeker, I want story-integrated learning elements so that tutorials don't break immersion	
Character Development	As a systems master, I want detailed customization options so that I can create a specialized character	As a story seeker, I want my character build to have an impact on the narrative of the game	As a focused student, I want clear progression paths so that I can purposefully develop my character efficiently the way I want it	
World	As a story seeker, I want to experience a mysterious and interesting world to be pulled into.	As a story seeker, I want a rich atmosphere so that I can immerse myself in the game	As a systems master, I want various locations with different gameplay opportunities so that I can optimize my strategy	As a focused student, I want recognizable academic environments so that I can relate to the setting
Dialog	As a story seeker, I want rich dialogue options so that I can express my character's personality	As a story seeker, I want deep NPC relationships so that I can develop meaningful connections	As a systems master, I want dialog mechanics that affect gameplay so that they have strategic value	As a systems master, I want skill-check dialogue options so that my character build affects conversations

Objectives	As a focused student, I want intellectually stimulating puzzles so that I feel mentally engaged	As a systems master, I want multiple problem-solving opportunities so that I can apply different character builds	As a story seeker, I want narrative-integrated tasks so that they enhance the story experience	As a focused student, I want missions that are not too long, to make it easier to step out of the game.
Story	As a story seeker, I want multiple narrative branches so that my choices matter	As a focused student, I want clearly structured story arcs so that I can follow the plot in short sessions	As a systems master, I want story choices that affect gameplay mechanics so that narrative decisions have strategic impact	

Competition analysis

In our analysis of the competition, we examine best and worst practices by evaluating reviews from various platforms, individual players, and experts. Our investigation specifically focuses on story elements, world-building approaches, skill systems, and methods of character expression. Given our goal to create a non-combat cRPG, combat systems receive minimal attention in this analysis. While turn-based tactical combat is a genre staple, implementing such a system without proper depth, tactical fidelity, and challenge often results in stale gameplay. Since creating a satisfying combat system would exceed the project's scope, we have opted to focus entirely on non-combat elements.

Non/Low-Combat CRPG Comparison Matrix

	Disco Elysium	**Planescape Torment**	**Torment: Tides of Numenera**
Genre	CRPG, Adventure	Adventure, CRPG	CRPG, Adventure
Developer	ZA/UM	Black Isle Studios	inXile Entertainment
Story	• Murder investigation in political city • Personal demons and amnesia • Strong philosophical & Political themes	• Philosophical journey of self-discovery • Amnesia-driven narrative • Philosophical focus: "What can change the nature of a man?"	• Central mystery narrative • Side quests connect to main plot • Heavy focus on personal identity • Philosophical questions throughout
World Building	• "New Weird" setting • Themes of poverty and addiction • Consistent dark humor • Postmodern aesthetic • Strong atmospheric direction	• D&D-based dark fantasy • Subverted fantasy tropes ○ Undead cities aren't evil • Philosophy shapes world	• Far-future Earth setting • Minimal familiar elements • Mystery-focused environment • Unique cultures and factions
Skill System	• Dice-based checks • 24 different skills • Skills provide narrative input • Perks offer additional effects • A lot of equipment with effects on skills	• Six core attributes • No additional skills • Tattoos instead of equipment bonuses • Passive flat checks unlock hidden dialogue options	• Three attributes • Percentage based checks • Regenerating point pool that auto complete checks • Late-game balance issues
Character Expression	• Extensive dialogue options • Perks unlocked through dialogue • Visual customization through clothing • Reactive NPCs	• No visual customization • Rich dialogue choices • D&D alignment	• Philosophical dialogue choices • Few visual options • Tide system for personality ○ Limited mechanical impact
Score	• IGN: 10/10 • Gamespot: 10/10 • Metacritic: 91/100 • Steam: Very Positive (58,205)	• IGN: 9.2/10 • Gamespot: 9/10 • Metacritic: 91/100 • Steam: Very Positive (3,075)	• IGN: 8.8/10 • Gamespot: 9/10 • Metacritic: 81/100 • Steam: Mostly Positive (1,756)

Decision-Centric CRPG Comparison Matrix

	Age of Decadence	**Tyranny**	**Pathfinder: Kingmaker**
Genre	Adventure, CRPG	CRPG	CRPG
Developer	Iron Tower Studio	Obsidian Entertainment	Owlcat Games
Story	• Multiple storylines based on faction choice • Mystery-driven world narrative • Short (~6h) • Choices unlock different missions	• Role of 'Fatebinder' in evil empire • Political conflict between generals • Multiple paths including rebellion • Strong focus on moral choices	• Slow-paced political narrative • Kingdom management focus • Long, expansive campaign (~70h)
World Building	• Post-apocalyptic Roman setting • Not Earth-based • Heavy focus on exploration • Mystery around old gods	• Bronze Age setting • Evil empire backdrop • Recently conquered territory • Political power dynamics	• Traditional fantasy world • Based on Pathfinder universe • Complex political landscape
Skill System	• 6 fixed starting attributes • Combat and non-combat skills • Binary pass/fail skill checks • Predictable check outcomes	• Mixed skills • Party-based skill system • Binary pass/fail skill checks • Combat-focused equipment	• 6 attributes • 11 different abilities • Complex class-based system • Party-based skill system
Character Expression	• Limited visual customization • Extensive dialogue options • Faction-based identity • Equipment has only minimal non-combat impact	• Expression through a large amount of choices • Faction-based identity • Combat-focused gear	• Alignment-based choices • Deep character customization class based • DnD based alignment
Score	• IGN: None • Gamespot: None • Metacritic: 81/100 • Steam: Very Positive (2.811)	• IGN: 8.3/10 • Gamespot: 8/10 • Metacritic: 80/100 • Steam: Very Positive (8,232)	• IGN: 6.9/10 • Gamespot: 6/10 • Metacritic: 73/100 • Steam: Mostly Positive (22,477)

Tactical CRPG Comparison Matrix

	Divinity: Original Sin 2	**Shadowrun Returns**	**Wasteland 2**
Genre	CRPG, TRPG	TRPG, CRPG	CRPG, TRPG
Developer	Larian Studios	Harebrained Schemes	inXile Entertainment
Story	• Multiple origin character stories • Choices affect ending • Strong central narrative	• Linear murder mystery • Conspiracy plot • Limited branching paths • Focused narrative scope	• Compartmentalized story sections • Different mood per area • Local consequences only
World Building	• High fantasy setting • Living, reactive world • Rich environmental interaction • Rewrites established Divinity Universe	• Cyberpunk fantasy setting • Limited exploration areas • Mission-focused spaces	• Apocalypse setting • Separated distinct areas • Moral and philosophical themes
Skill System	• Item-based ability acquisition • Combat-focused abilities • Limited non-combat skills	• Linear progression per skills ○ Abilities unlocked by selection • Six preset archetypes	• Diverse skill options • Party skill distribution • Not all skills learnable • Wide set of non-combat skills
Character Expression	• Multiple origin characters • Race/gender/background options • Combat-centric development	• Race/archetype selection • Custom character option • Limited dialogue choices • Combat-centric development	• Full visual customization • Moral based decisions
Score	• IGN: 9.2/10 • Gamespot: 9/10 • Metacritic: 91/100 • Steam: Very Positive (3,075)	• IGN: 7.3/10 • Gamespot: 8/10 • Metacritic: 76/100 • Steam: Very Positive (8.705)	• IGN: 8.4/10 • Gamespot: 8/10 • Metacritic: 81/100 • Steam: Very Positive (4,557)

Conclusion

Best Practices:

- Strong narrative hooks combining personal stakes with larger themes (mystery, philosophy, politics)
- Distinctive settings that break from traditional fantasy tropes
- Skill systems that meaningfully impact both dialogue and exploration
- Character expression through dialogue choices and faction allegiances
- Equipment and customization that affects gameplay beyond combat stats
- Multiple solution paths that respect different character builds
- Rich world reactivity and NPC interactions

Worst Practices:

- Overly complex skill systems that don't add meaningful choices
- Binary pass/fail checks without interesting failure states
- Disconnected narrative sections that lack cohesive impact
- Limited character expression through visual or mechanical means
- Systems that become trivial or unbalanced in late-game
- Excessive length that dilutes the core experience
- Combat systems that feel disconnected from narrative elements

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Pestel

This PESTEL analysis examines the macro-environmental factors affecting the gaming industry specifically within the German market. The analysis considers national political initiatives, economic trends, social developments, technological advancements, environmental concerns, and legal framework within Germany's borders, providing a comprehensive overview of the market conditions.

Political

The German Ministry of Digital and Transport promotes the expansion of digital transportation routes, among other things, with the justification of providing better infrastructure for online games and game distribution. Various game developments are also funded by the federal government, and significant successes have already been achieved after a test phase. Therefore, the government promotes the gaming industry.

Economical

The German gaming market demonstrates robust and consistent growth. According to market analysis, consumer spending on video games in Germany has nearly doubled from 4.329 billion euros in 2017 to approximately 8 billion euros in 2023. This upward trajectory is expected to continue, with projections indicating the market will reach nearly 10 billion euros by 2028. This sustained growth in the German gaming sector indicates strong market potential and consumer engagement, despite global economic fluctuations.

Social

Socially, the number of players has increased from 36% to up to 50% of Germans since 2013. This shows an increasing acceptance of the gaming industry. A study from 2021 showed that 80% of 16-29 year-olds play video games, while only 40% of 50-64 year-olds play. It is highly likely that many of the current young people will maintain their hobby and the proportion of older video game players will accordingly increase in the coming years. A study from the same year has shown that 43% of gamers are PC players.

Technological

Technologically, the biggest technological challenges have been DDoS attacks, the availability of technology professionals, and a slow internet connection. Currently, research and development is being conducted on cloud-based game technology, VR and/or AR formats, and the integration of AI and machine learning in games. These developments are genre-independent.

Environmental

Environmentally, as the performance of new generations of graphics cards and other hardware components increases, so does their power consumption, if not green, it harms the environment. With the new cloud technology, large server farms are added which require more

power than local gaming and generate a large amount of data, which would require telecommunications providers to expand their infrastructure. However, the industry is aware of this and works to balance the resulting CO2 footprint with reforestation or themed work in the games.

Legal

Legally, video games can be protected by copyright, for example, by protecting the code as text or images and graphics in the game. In addition, games can affect the health and development of children, accordingly, developers must be aware of the content in the games and to whom these games are directed. It is recommended to take measures to prevent children and young people from being exposed to harmful games.

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Demo

A playable demo of THMastery has been created to test and validate the core gameplay systems. Built around the introduction area and the main entrance of building A10, the demo provides a vertical slice that demonstrates the game's dialogue systems, skill checks, task structure and player progression.

Introduction Area



The intro area is the first area of the game. You end up here, when you start a new game.

In it there are some small tasks, NPCs and pick ups to introduce the player to all the basic mechanics of the game in a controlled environment.

The player starts directly next to the entrance and only exit, which is currently blocked. The closest NPCs are the group blocking the exit and the teacher. In dialog the group guides the player to the teacher. He therefore is subtly guided towards his first task, that if done, releases them from the intro area.



In it, the player is tasked with asking all the non-group NPCs if they are ready. It is also possible to finish the quest by achieving a bluff check, pretending you already asked everyone.

The NPCs are the following:

- The chill guy: He is ready and also offers a coffee that can be used later.
- Terence Rex: He is also ready, but you have to navigate through a rather lengthy dialog chain. In this interaction the player can choose the name of the NPC as well as gaining or losing affinity with him.
- The sleepy guy: He is tired and not ready, until bringing him a coffee. Coffee is available from the chill guy and next to the ignoring group. In a background bluff check the player is also informed that they can take the group's food and coffee. Bringing him the coffee awards a small amount of experience and 5€.

After having checked the readiness of two of these people. The difficulty of the previous bluff check towards the teacher is lowered. Having talked to all of the people, the teacher can be informed, finishing the quest and starting the introduction. All student NPCs are moved to the seats opening the exit. Additionally a speech is given informing the player about the rooms and classes they will have to undergo.

This information with some extras can be reread on the computer next to the exit. Next to the exit the player can also find a flier providing extra knowledge about SMS.

A10 - Entrance Area

The entrance area of Building A10 is divided into three distinct sections: the Pastaria on the left, the main entrance with its side rooms in the middle, and the canteen on the right. Players arriving from the introduction spawn near the stairs at the main entrance, where they have complete freedom of movement, including access to the outside through an animated front door.



The Pastaria (Left Wing)

The Pastaria hosts a small set of activities and opportunities. A dedicated Flyer Girl NPC maintains a permanent station here, offering to exchange any flyers players collect for €1 each. The area is equipped with three vending machines that stock Category C food items for quick refreshments.

In the center of the Pastaria is an ongoing birthday party celebration. Here, players can spot a birthday cake, one of the game's at this stage of the game rare Category A food items. The party guests will reveal that obtaining such a cake requires a special codeword, which they'll only share in exchange for a present.



Player options at the party:

- Request information about obtaining a cake (requires bringing a present)
- Steal the cake (requires athletics check to escape if party guests are approached after)
- Take a party cone without consequences
- Note: Attempting to talk your way out of theft increases escape difficulty

Main Entrance Area (Center)

The central entrance area serves as the building's primary travel hub, connecting multiple locations through various doors and passages. Players can access:

- The campus through exit doors
- The different levels of the building through the elevator (different levels are not in the demo)
- The basement through the stairs (leading to a dev room)
- The introduction area through the other stairs

Near the spawn point, players can meet Caitlyn, who offers a quest leading to a task on the campus. In the bottom left corner is the AStA store offering an assortment of items.
The area's most significant feature is the storage room tucked away in the bottom left corner. The storage room can be accessed in two ways: either through a passive luck check requiring

4 points (achievable through collecting specific items), or by obtaining the master key from the bathroom:



- Achieve 4 luck points through items (passive check):
    - Party cone
    - Lucky 8 ball from canteen
    - Consumed birthday cake
- Obtain the master key from the bathroom toilet by:
    - Passing a will check
    - Using a plunger
    - Getting information from the trash master (lowers difficulty of will check significantly)

The storage room holds valuable rewards:

- Trench coat
- Detective hat
- Clutter pile (requires creativity check for birthday party present)
- Plunger

Master Key Uses:

- Return to janitor for substantial reward
- Access service elevator to different levels
- Open storage room directly

The Mensa (Right Wing)



The mensa offers higher category food items. A prominent menu board greets visitors, listing an array of Category B food items for purchase alongside premium Category A meals. Behind the counter, players can acquire an apron.

The space serves as more than just food vendors - it's also a npc hub where players can get a small task from Kevin - to answer a few questions-, or help Mario by bringing him a much-needed donut for his blood sugar each rewarding 20 XP. The pool table in the corner houses a lucky 8 ball.

Available Items:

- Category A Cakes (behind counter with the passwort from the birthday party)
- Category B food items (general purchase)
- Apron (behind counter)
- Lucky 8 ball (at pool table)
- 3 Oranges (on one of the tables)

Campus

The demo area includes a small section of the A-Campus, primarily focused around Building A10. While more campus areas are planned for future expansion, currently only A10 and its immediate surroundings are accessible.

The A10 Area

Building A10 is located on the left side of the campus grounds. A narrow alley runs along its south side, filled with trash bins and discarded items. Though it may appear unremarkable, the alley contains several important items and an unusual vendor.

The Trash Master's Domain

In the alley, players can find a vendor who calls himself the Trash Master. He sells both information and various items:



Available Information:

- Master key location hints (2€)
- Worksite key location details (2€)

Items for Purchase:

- Plunger - useful for master key retrieval (5€)
- Bolt Hat (8€)
- Balaclava (10€)

The Worksite

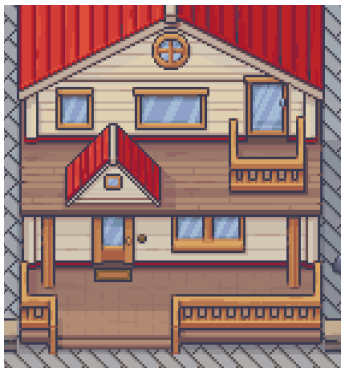


Next to A10 is a worksite that requires a key to enter. The workers in front of it mention losing their key while taking out the trash. Players can find this key among the trash in the alley. Inside the worksite, players can find:

- A worker's helmet
- Access to a hidden pond area containing a collectable fish

The Red House

A red house is located in this area. It is needed to complete Caitlyn's task from the A20 entrance.

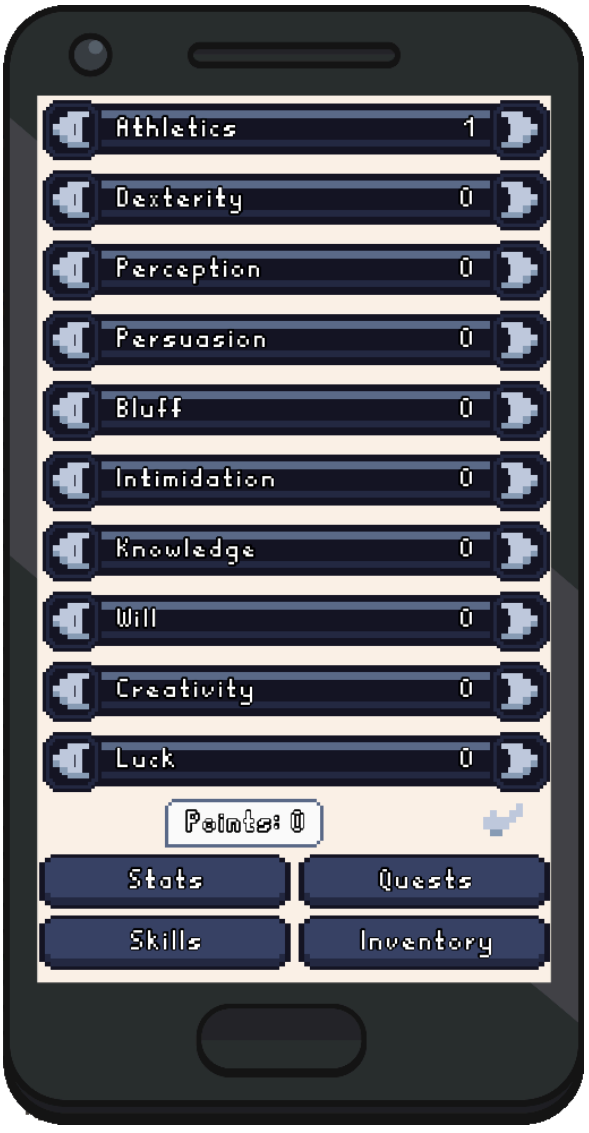


Implemented User Interface

The demo implements most of the game's user interface elements, though currently in a preliminary style. While the core functionality is present, both the visual design and certain interface elements will be refined and updated for the final release.

Menu structure

The game's interface is designed around a smartphone container, with each menu styled as a mobile application to maintain thematic consistency with the modern university setting.



Attribute Menu

The Attribute Menu is where players manage their character's attributes and distribute attribute points as they level up.

The interface displays all ten attributes with their current values. Players can distribute available attribute points to any attribute they choose. When allocating points, players have the opportunity to revise their decisions before making them permanent - changes only become locked in once the confirm button is pressed. If a player closes the screen without confirming, all distributed points return to the available pool.

The menu uses a smartphone-style interface, with ten attribute bars arranged vertically. Each bar displays the attribute name on the left and its numerical value on the right, with arrow buttons on either side for adjustment. Below the attributes, a Points counter shows available points.

Each attribute bar includes tooltips explaining each attribute's function.

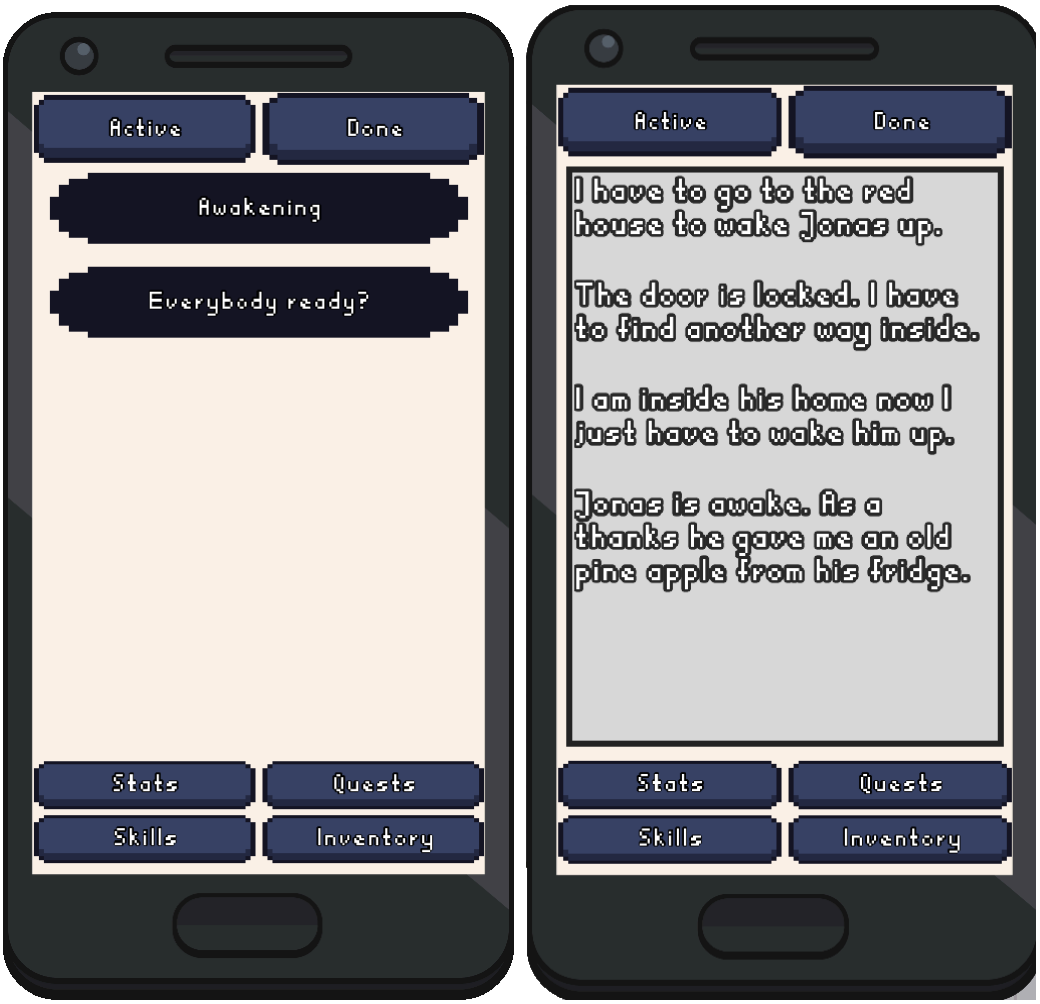
In future iterations attributes will be color-coded according to their respective groups.

Task Menu

The Task Menu tracks the player's active and completed tasks during their playthrough.

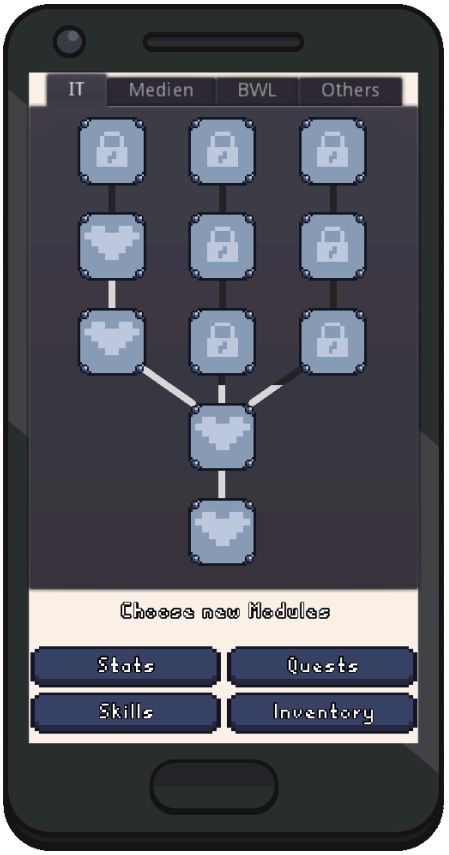
Tasks are organized into two categories: active and completed, accessible through tabs at the top of the screen. Each task appears as a selectable button displaying its name. When a task is selected, a detailed description window opens showing the task's current state and objectives.

The current selection's description appears in a scrollable text window below the tabs, automatically updating with new information as the task progresses. The description grows longer as more steps are completed, maintaining a history of the player's progress.



Skill Menu

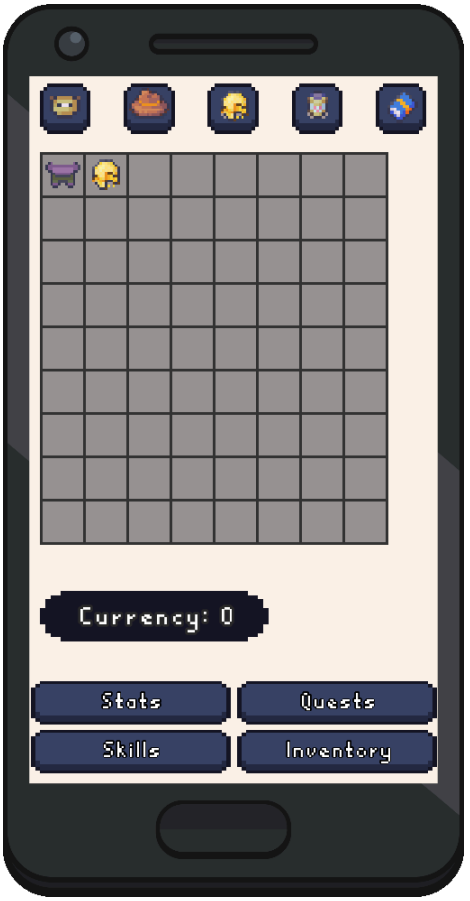
The Skill Menu displays all available and acquired skills that players can obtain through completing courses in their academic journey as well as hinting at future skills.



Skills are presented in a branching tree structure that mirrors real university course prerequisites and dependencies. Each node in the tree represents a course or skill, with connecting lines showing progression paths and requirements. Players can view details about each course, including the teaching professor and location, through tooltips on the nodes.

The tree visualization uses various visual states to communicate skill status: locked skills show a lock symbol, available skills appear grayed-out but selectable, and acquired skills are fully lit. The connecting lines between skills are also dynamic - partially filled lines indicate available progression paths, while fully lit lines show completed prerequisites. When unlocking a new skill, an animation plays and the node lights up to provide clear feedback. The current tree layout shown in the interface is a placeholder that will be replaced with the final course structure.

Inventory Menu



The Inventory Menu allows players to manage their collected items and monitor their current currency.

Items are displayed in a grid-based layout where players can organize and interact with their collected possessions. Players can filter their inventory between different categories including general items, clothing, food, consumables, and miscellaneous items for better organization.

The interface displays the current currency amount at the bottom of the screen, with categorization tabs at the top for filtering. The inventory grid automatically expands when full, adding a scroll bar to accommodate additional items while maintaining the menu's clean layout.

Game Menu

The Game Menu provides access to essential game management functions and settings.

The menu presents six primary options arranged vertically: Continue resumes the current game session, New Game starts a fresh playthrough, Save stores the current game state, Load retrieves previously saved games, Options accesses game settings, and Desktop exits to the computer's desktop.

The interface uses simple button navigation, with each option clearly labeled in a pixel art style consistent with the game's visual theme.

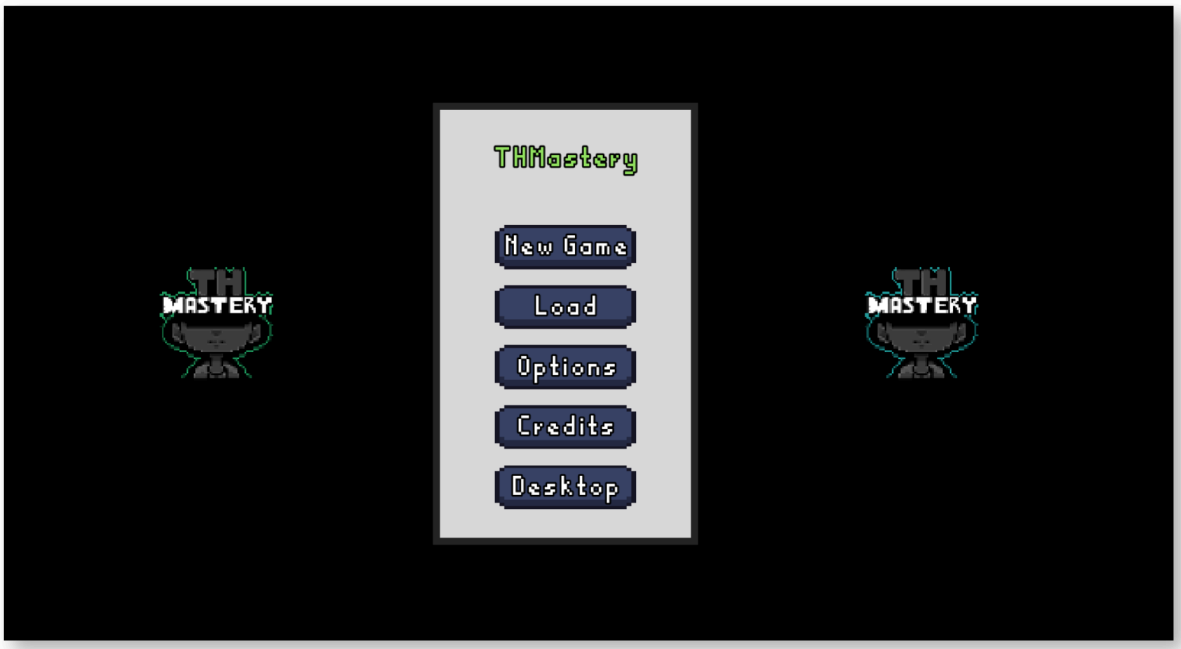


Title Screen

The Title Screen serves as the player's first point of entry into the game.

Like the Game Menu, it offers options to start a new game, load a saved game, access options, view credits, or return to the desktop. The save option is naturally omitted as no game is in progress.

The interface features the game's title "THMastery" at the top, with navigation buttons arranged vertically in the center of the screen. The background showcases the game's logo alternating with animated gameplay footage, creating a dynamic presentation of the game's content.



Options Menu

The Options Menu allows players to customize their control scheme and audio settings.

Players can modify key bindings for all major game functions including movement, menu access, and interactions. When selecting a control to change, the game waits for the player's new input to assign to that function.

The interface displays all configurable controls in a list format, with current key assignments shown next to each function. A music toggle option is currently implemented, with plans to expand audio settings in future updates to include separate sound controls.

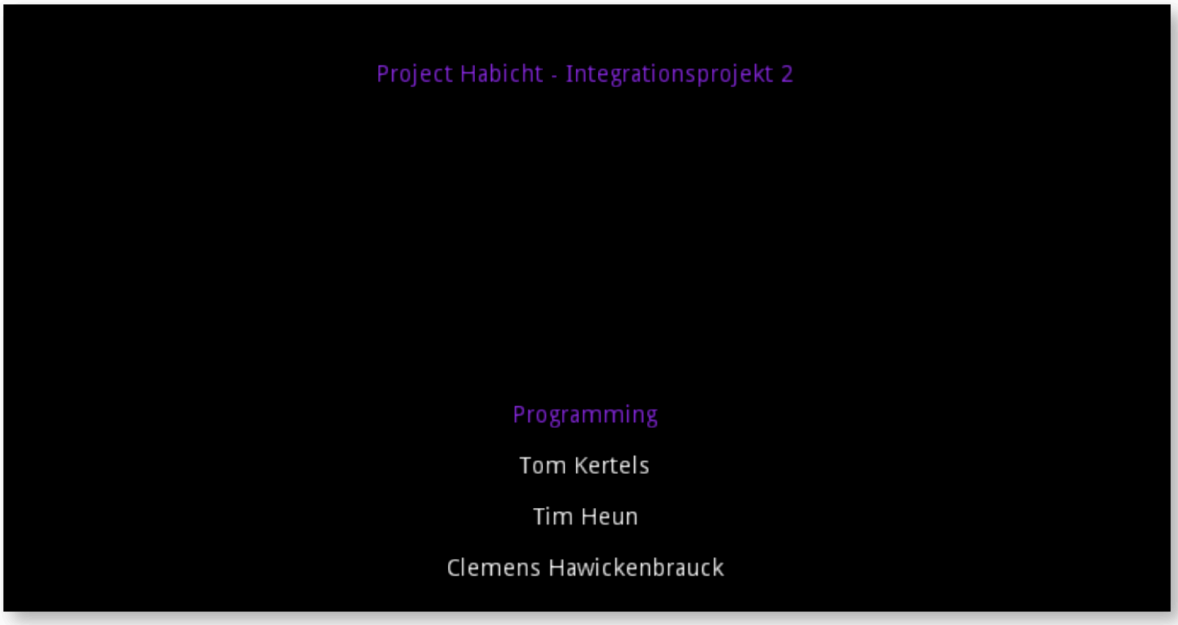


Credits

The Credits Screen acknowledges the developers and their contributions to the game.

Credits automatically scroll vertically from bottom to top, listing each team member's name under their respective development area.

The interface uses a simple black background with purple headers and white text for names, using a scrolling animation.



HUD elements

The HUD provides essential real-time information to the player, positioned in the bottom left corner of the screen.

The central element is the nerve bar, which displays the player's current mental state with both a numerical value and a facial expression icon. Hovering over the bar reveals the exact nerve points remaining and maximum capacity. Surrounding the nerve bar are three key information areas: temporary effects stack above it, the currently active food item appears to the right, and a row of menu shortcut buttons sit below.

The interface arranges four quick-access menu buttons beneath the nerve bar: Attribute Menu, Inventory Menu, Task Menu, and Game Menu, providing easy navigation to core game functions fully reachable with the mouse.

